

A PLOTBREW WRITING WORKBOOK

THE ROMANTASY WORLDBUILDING WORKBOOK



Build worlds worth falling in love in.

What This Is

This is a worldbuilding workbook designed specifically for romantasy — fantasy romance where the world isn't just backdrop, but an active force shaping and pressuring the love story.

In romantasy, worldbuilding isn't separate from romance. The political marriage that forces enemies together, the magical bond that connects two people against their will, the ancient feud that makes love forbidden, the class divide that seems impossible to cross — these aren't setting details. They're the engine of your story.

This workbook helps you build worlds that create romantic tension by design.

Who This Is For

This workbook is for writers who want to:

- Build fantasy worlds that feel real and internally consistent
- Create external obstacles that pressure and test relationships
- Understand how geography, politics, magic, culture, and history can generate romantic conflict
- Move beyond generic fantasy settings to worlds that could only produce *your* story
- Develop worldbuilding that readers will want to live in

Whether you're writing your first romantasy or your tenth, whether you're a plotter who needs everything mapped before drafting or a pantsier who discovers your world as you go — this workbook meets you where you are.

How This Workbook Is Structured

Each section follows a two-part structure:

Part One: The Foundation

This is the worldbuilding itself — how your geography, magic, government, religion, economy, culture, or history actually works. These elements exist in your world regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Strong foundations make your world feel real. Readers can tell when a world has depth versus when it's cardboard scenery hastily assembled behind the love story.

Part Two: [Topic] & Romance

This is where worldbuilding becomes romantic tension. Each section shows you how to mine its topic for obstacles, intimacy, stakes, and conflict specific to love stories.

A magic system isn't just about what spells exist — it's about what happens when one character is vastly more powerful than the other, or when a magical bond forces intimacy neither chose, or when using power for someone you love costs something real.

REMEMBER

You need both parts. A romance between a servant and a prince needs a believable class system (foundation) that actually creates stakes and obstacles for their relationship (romance application). Skip the foundation and your world feels thin. Skip the romance application and you're not using your world to its full potential.

How to Use This Workbook

You Don't Have to Do Everything

This workbook is comprehensive — intentionally so. Not every section will apply to your story. Not every question will be relevant.

Skip freely. If your story doesn't involve inter-species romance, skip that section. If religion isn't a factor, move past it. If your characters aren't part of an institution, those questions aren't for you.

The goal isn't to fill every blank. The goal is to build what your specific story needs.

You Don't Have to Go in Order

The sections are numbered for reference, not because you must complete them sequentially.

Some writers start with magic because that's the heart of their world. Others start with the political situation that creates their central conflict. Some build geography first because place shapes everything else.

Start wherever you have the most energy or the clearest vision. Let that section inform the others.

Focus on What Creates Stakes

As you work through each section, keep asking: **How does this create obstacles for my characters?**

Not every piece of worldbuilding needs to directly pressure the romance — some details just make the world feel real. But if you find yourself developing elaborate systems that never touch your love story, you might be worldbuilding for worldbuilding's sake rather than story's sake.

The best romantasy worldbuilding does double duty: it makes the world feel real *and* it makes the romance feel impossible (until it isn't).

Use the Integration Checks

At the end of each section, you'll find Integration Checks — questions that connect that section's topic to others. These are important.

Worlds feel real when their systems interact. A magic system affects government (who has power). Religion shapes culture (what's taboo). History explains current politics (why the feud exists). Geography determines economy (who controls resources).

If each section exists in isolation, your world will feel like a collection of unrelated details. Integration Checks help you weave everything together.

Examples Are Guides, Not Rules

Throughout this workbook, you'll find examples drawn from popular romantasy novels — ACOTAR, Fourth Wing, From Blood and Ash, Serpent & Dove, and others. These show what good answers look like and what level of specificity is useful.

But these examples aren't templates to copy. Your world should be *yours*. Use the examples to understand the kind of thinking these questions invite, then develop answers that serve your unique story.

A Note on Tropes

Romantasy is a trope-heavy genre, and that's not a weakness — it's a feature. Readers come to romantasy *wanting* enemies-to-lovers, forced proximity, forbidden love, fated mates, morally grey love interests, and "there's only one bed."

This workbook doesn't shy away from tropes. Instead, it helps you execute them well.

The difference between a tired trope and a beloved one isn't the trope itself — it's the execution. An enemies-to-lovers romance where the enmity is shallow and easily overcome is boring. An enemies-to-lovers romance where both characters have genuine, legitimate reasons to hate each other — where choosing love means betraying everything they believed — that's compelling.

CORE PRINCIPLE

■ *Worldbuilding is how you make tropes feel earned.*

The forced proximity isn't just "they're stuck together" — it's the specific institution, geography, political situation, or magical bond that makes escape impossible.

The forbidden love isn't just "they're not supposed to be together" — it's the specific laws, cultural taboos, religious strictures, or historical enmity that makes their love dangerous.

Build your world to support your tropes, and your tropes will sing.

Before You Begin

You don't need to know your whole story before starting. Many writers discover their plots through worldbuilding — realizing that the magic system they developed creates a perfect obstacle, or that the political situation they built suggests an ending they hadn't considered.

Let the worldbuilding work *with* your story, not as a separate task you complete before writing.

And remember: worldbuilding exists to serve the story. A beautifully detailed world that doesn't create stakes for your characters is just a setting guide. A sparse world that perfectly pressures your romance is doing its job.

Build what you need. Skip what you don't. Make a world worth falling in love in.

The Sections

SECTION	TOPIC	WHAT IT COVERS
1	Geography & Environment	Physical world, climate, travel, how place creates obstacles
2	Flora, Fauna & Ecosystems	Plants, animals, bonded creatures, inter-species romance
3	Culture, Customs & Daily Life	Social norms, taboos, courtship, what's forbidden
4	Economy, Labor & Resources	Wealth, class, debt, what money means for love
5	Government, Power & Law	Politics, law, forbidden relationships, enemies-to-lovers
6	Religion, Myth & Prophecy	Faith, vows, divine purpose, what the gods demand
7	History & Lore	The past that haunts the present, inherited conflict
8	Magic System	How magic works, magical bonds, power dynamics

Additional Sections (9–21) cover specialized topics: technology, time & calendar, language, magic conflicts, pressure cooker settings, institutions, and more.

Appendix A: Revealing Worldbuilding in Prose — A practical guide to deploying your worldbuilding in scenes without info-dumps.

Let's Begin

Turn to whichever section calls to you first. There's no wrong starting point.

Your world is waiting to be built.

SECTION ONE

GEOGRAPHY & ENVIRONMENT

Geography in romantasy serves a dual function. It builds a believable world, sure, but it also does something more intimate: it determines if your characters can ever meet one another. A mountain range separating two kingdoms is not simply a border. It creates the only viable opportunity for an alliance through marriage. That isolated academy isn't just a cool setting. The isolation of the academy is the reason why your character can't leave this person who infuriates her.

Every river, every desert, every castle wall in your world will be either drawing your characters closer together or keeping them apart. Build geography with that in mind, and your setting ceases to be a passive backdrop and begins to create your story.

This section is divided into two parts:

Part One: The Foundation covers the physical reality of your world. Terrain, climate, resources, dangers, and how geography shapes where and how people live. This is the geographic baseline that exists regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Part Two: Geography & Romance covers how physical geography creates romantic tension. Separation and proximity, dangerous journeys together, entering each other's worlds, places that hold emotional meaning.

You need both.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. **Skip what doesn't fit.**

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want. A richly developed world has value beyond what appears on the page. Use the "romance connection" prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank if that element is just background texture.

Come back later. If you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it and return once your story has taken more shape.

This workbook is a tool, not a test.

How to Think About Geography in Romantasy

Geography in romantasy functions as a **pressure system**. The physical world can compress your characters together, force them apart, or create conditions where they must rely on each other. Before you draw a map, ask yourself: *What geographic situation does my romance need?*

Not every hill and river needs to serve the plot. But the geography you foreground, the locations where scenes happen, the terrain your characters traverse, the distances between them, should be doing something. Background geography creates atmosphere and believability. Foreground geography creates story.

The “Pressure Cooker” Principle

The best romantasy settings act like pressure cookers: environments that create friction between your characters by compressing them together, holding them apart, or forcing impossible choices. In situations where the physical world limits your characters’ ability to move away from one another, escape each other’s company, or take the path of least resistance, then your setting has done half of the work to create the relationship.

Geography creates friction in three ways.

Proximity friction forces characters together despite themselves. A snowed-in mountain pass, a ship voyage with no escape, an isolated academy, a dangerous journey requiring partnership. When your characters can’t leave each other alone, then they will be forced to confront conflict instead of avoiding it, rely on each other despite distrust, and share space long enough for attraction to build beneath their defences. It is the small things that add up. Shared meals. Overheard conversations. Accidental touches in tight quarters.

That is why Basgiath War College works so well in *Fourth Wing*. The war college is literally carved into the side of rugged cliffs, and even getting in requires surviving the Parapet, a lethal crossing that establishes the stakes before classes even begin. Once you’re inside, there’s no leaving. The sparring gym forces mandatory physical contact. The dorms provide little to no private space. And when Violet’s and Xaden’s dragons turn out to be mates, their biology adds yet another layer of confinement; the riders physically can’t stay apart for more than a few days without suffering for it. The combination of the environment and the bond between the two creates a situation where the characters cannot remain separated from each other. As a result, these two have to deal with each other whether they want to or not. The setting generates the romance.

Separation friction will keep your characters separated as well as physically apart from each other. An ocean that takes months to cross, separate kingdoms behind a mountain range, a magical barrier that requires certain conditions for safe passage, war zones that make travel deadly. Separation makes physical separation feel heavy and the distance meaningful. Each time someone leaves and returns the experience is emotionally charged, and the question of who’ll cross the divide (and what it costs them) becomes a declaration in itself.

Resource friction presents obstacles that both characters have to overcome. Rights to use limited water resources in a desert area, the only pass through the mountains, a rare magical resource found in contested territory, trade routes that require cooperation between enemies. As long as the people your characters represent are at odds over a piece of geography, the romantic relationship will have to find a way to address this tension whether either party wants to or not.

Now consider what seals the pressure cooker tight in your world:

- **Physical trapping:** Islands, schools, sieges, ships, remote estates. Places with real boundaries that your characters cannot cross.
- **Circumstantial trapping:** Wilderness that requires your characters to partner to survive, diplomatic missions, shared exile. Situations where separating means failure or death.
- **Environmental trapping:** Storms, seasons, magic that prevents your characters from leaving. Forces outside of your characters that make leaving impossible no matter their wishes.
- **Social/political trapping:** Arranged marriages, hostage situations, obligations to the courts. Scenarios in which leaving would result in harm to their reputation, alliances or the lives of others.

You may feel that if your geography does not cause friction for your characters then the geography is wasted space; however, this is not necessarily true. It's just setting. But the geography that you choose to focus on should be causing your characters to come together, pulling them apart, or forcing them to choose. If your characters could simply leave each other behind, would they? If the answer is yes, your geography needs to make it impossible, too dangerous or too costly for them to do so.

The Pressure Cooker: Your Story

What type of geographic friction does your romance need most?

Think about the core dynamic of your love story. Do your characters need to be trapped together (proximity), kept apart (separation), or forced to negotiate over something (resource)? Most romances use more than one, but one tends to dominate.

FRICTION TYPE	HOW IT SHOWS UP IN YOUR STORY	WHAT IT FORCES YOUR CHARACTERS TO DO
<i>Proximity</i>	<i>Violet and Xaden are trapped at Basgiath — can't leave, paired for training, dragons are bonded</i>	<i>They must confront their hostility daily instead of avoiding each other</i>
Proximity		
Separation		
Resource		

What seals the pressure cooker in your world?

Check the trapping types that apply and describe how they work in your story. The strongest setups use more than one.

TRAPPING TYPE	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR WORLD
Physical (islands, walls, academies)		
Circumstantial (must partner to survive)		
Environmental (storms, seasons, magic)		
Social/political (obligations, hostage, arranged marriage)		

Could your characters simply walk away from each other?

If the answer is yes, your pressure cooker has a leak. What makes leaving impossible, too dangerous, or too costly?

YOUR ANSWER

Common Geographic Patterns in Romantasy

Settings That Force Proximity

SETTING TYPE	WHY IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The Academy/Training Ground	Characters live, train, and compete in close quarters with no escape	<i>Fourth Wing, Zodiac Academy</i>
The Isolated Estate	Limited cast, limited space, limited options for avoidance	Gothic romances, <i>Pride and Prejudice</i> variations
The Ship/Caravan	Moving container with enforced proximity and shared danger	Pirate romance, trade caravan stories
The Siege/War Camp	External threat forces cooperation; death is the alternative	Military romantasy
The Prison/Captivity	Hostage and captor, shared cell, or trapped in enemy territory together	Captive romance, enemies-to-lovers
The Dangerous Quest	Mission requires partnership; separating means failure or death	Quest narratives, escort missions
The Snowed-In/Stranded	Weather or disaster traps characters until conditions change	Cabin romance, “only one bed”
The Royal Court	Political obligations, arranged proximity, can’t leave without scandal	Court intrigue, political marriage

Geographic Barriers That Create Stakes

BARRIER TYPE	ROMANTIC FUNCTION	STORY POSSIBILITIES
Mountain ranges	Separate nations/cultures; make travel seasonal	Characters from opposite sides; winter trapping
Oceans	Create complete separation; make departure permanent	Letters across distance; the weight of leaving
Deserts	Isolate cultures; make resources precious	Oasis politics; survival journeys
Magical borders	Can be crossed only by certain people or under certain conditions	One character can cross, one can't
War zones	Make travel deadly; create no-man's-land between peoples	Enemies from opposing sides
Political borders	Crossing means treason or exile	Forbidden love across enemy lines
Cursed/Blighted lands	Regions too dangerous to cross; require special protection	Must find another way; one character immune, one isn't
Class geography	Slums vs. palace district; social ruin to cross	Wrong-side-of-tracks romance; secret meetings in between spaces

Environmental Conditions That Affect Romance

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Harsh winters	Traps characters indoors; requires shared warmth	Forced proximity; "snowed in" scenarios
Dangerous nights	Characters must shelter together after dark	Shared watch; protective sleeping arrangements

CONDITION	HOW IT CREATES PRESSURE	ROMANTIC BEATS IT ENABLES
Seasonal access	Passes close, ships can't sail, travel becomes impossible	Racing against time; trapped until spring
Resource scarcity	Sharing becomes necessary; generosity becomes meaningful	Sharing food/water; sacrifice for the other
Extreme heat	Travel only possible at night; requires shade-sharing, water rationing	Night travel intimacy; sharing precious water; heat exhaustion care
Hostile territory after dark	Monsters or predators hunt at night; must camp together for safety	One bed/bedroll situations; taking turns on watch; protective instincts
Corrupted/poisoned land	Regions that drain magic or health; must move quickly or rely on healer	Dependency on one character's abilities; racing against deterioration

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: The Rubber-Band World

Geography bends to suit the plot. Characters travel vast distances between chapters with no sense of time passing, and geographic features appear or disappear as needed. A mountain range exists to separate characters but conveniently vanishes when they need to reunite. If distance has no weight, separation has no stakes and reunion carries no emotional punch. Barriers that can be waved away whenever it's convenient are barriers readers stop believing in. The geography that's supposed to keep your characters apart needs to feel immovable, or the tension of being apart means nothing.

FIX

Establish your geography and travel times early, then let them constrain you. If crossing the mountains takes three weeks, that's three weeks of separation your characters have to live with, or three weeks of travelling together that changes everything. Let the physical world create problems you didn't plan for. Those problems often generate the best scenes.

Mistake #2: The Empty Map

You've got a map with named places, but none of them feel lived-in. The geography exists, but it doesn't affect anything. Geography should create culture, which creates characters, which creates conflict. If your geography doesn't explain why people are the way they are, your world is just a painted backdrop.

FIX

For every major geographic feature, ask: *How does this shape the people who live here?* Let geography explain cultural difference.

Mistake #3: Geography Without Emotional Resonance

You describe the setting in detail, but it’s all physical. Mountains are tall, forests are dense, cities are crowded. None of it connects to how your characters feel. Setting should be emotional landscape. The place where they first met should feel different from other places. The character’s homeland should feel like *home*.

FIX

Give each major location an emotional quality, and let characters experience it differently. The same castle might feel like a prison to one character and a sanctuary to another.

Geography Self-Check

Review the geography you’ve built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Rubber-Band World: Travel times or distances change to suit the plot		
Empty Map: Locations exist but don’t affect culture, conflict, or character		
No Emotional Resonance: Setting is described physically but never connected to how characters feel		

The Big Picture: Your World's Scale

What's the geographic scope of your story?

Check the scope that best fits your story, then note the primary locations where your romance actually takes place.

SCOPE	✓	PRIMARY LOCATION(S)
Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)	✓	Thornwick Academy — a remote magical school on sea cliffs where students are trapped together for the term
Single city/location (isolated island, palace, academy)		
Single region (kingdom, province, territory)		
Multiple regions (nations, continents)		
Entire world (epic scope)		
Multiple worlds/realms (parallel dimensions, portals)		

If your world is large, where specifically does your romance happen?

You don't need to detail everything — just locations that matter.

LOCATION TYPE	NAME/DESCRIPTION
<i>Primary location</i>	<i>The Winter Court — an ice palace where protagonist is held hostage, forced into proximity with the prince</i>
Primary location	
Secondary location	
Secondary location	

Kingdoms & Nations Overview

This is reference material. Fill in what you know now; come back as your world develops.

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 1	KINGDOM/NATION 2
Name		
Capital		
Neighbouring lands		
Known for		
Main industry/resource		
Climate		

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 1	KINGDOM/NATION 2
Primary species		
Religion		
Government type		
Allies		
Enemies/rivals		
Notable landmark		
Role in your story		

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 1	KINGDOM/NATION 2
Romantic function (how does this nation create or complicate your love story?)		

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 3	KINGDOM/NATION 4
Name		
Capital		
Neighbouring lands		
Known for		
Main industry/resource		

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 3	KINGDOM/NATION 4
Climate		
Primary species		
Religion		
Government type		
Allies		
Enemies/rivals		
Notable landmark		

ASPECT	KINGDOM/NATION 3	KINGDOM/NATION 4
Role in your story		
Romantic function (how does this nation create or complicate your love story?)		

How does the relationship between these kingdoms/nations affect your romance?

Are your characters from rival nations? Allied ones? Does one kingdom control something the other needs?

The political geography between nations often becomes the romantic geography between lovers.

YOUR ANSWER

Terrain Types

Only fill in terrains that matter. If your characters never see a desert, skip it.

What terrains shape your story?

TERRAIN	WHERE?	WHAT IT PROVIDES	WHAT CHALLENGES IT CREATES	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANCE
Mountains	Northern border between kingdoms	Natural defense, mineral deposits	Impassable in winter, treacherous passes	Separates protagonist's and love interest's kingdoms; winter trapping forces the arranged-marriage alliance

TERRAIN	WHERE?	WHAT IT PROVIDES	WHAT CHALLENGES IT CREATES	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANCE

Naming Places

Good place names make your world feel real. You don't need to invent a whole language for this; just notice how real places get their names.

Most come from geography (Blackwood, Riverside), historical figures (Washington), or descriptions in old languages (Oxford means "ford where oxen cross"). Borrow the patterns, not the exact words.

In romantasy, naming matters most when your characters come from different cultures. Distinct naming conventions instantly signal "these people are not the same," and a character learning to pronounce names from their love interest's language, or discovering what a place name means, can be a quiet intimacy beat. If your two kingdoms share naming patterns, readers will assume shared heritage. If the names feel completely alien to each other, readers feel the cultural distance your characters have to cross.

Researching Naming Conventions

If you want place names that evoke a particular culture or aesthetic, here's how to find patterns yourself:

- **Search "[language] place name meanings"** e.g., "Old Norse place name meanings" or "Welsh place name elements"
- **Search "[language] words for [terrain]"** e.g., "Japanese words for mountain" or "Gaelic words for river"

- **Look up real places.** Search “etymology of [real place name]” to see how actual names were constructed.
- **Wikipedia’s toponymy pages.** Search “[language] toponymy” for organised lists of place name elements.
- **Behind the Name.** The website behindthename.com has a place names section with etymologies.

For deeper language work, see *Section 11: Language & Communication*.

Reference: Common English Place Name Patterns

Mix prefixes and suffixes to generate names. “Ash” + “ford” = Ashford. “Black” + “moor” = Blackmoor.

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-ham	homestead, village	Nottingham
-ton / -town	fenced settlement	Brighton
-ford	river crossing	Oxford
-ley / -leigh	clearing, meadow	Barnsley
-dale / -vale	valley	Airedale
-burgh / -bury	fortified place	Edinburgh
-port	harbor, market town	Southport
-moor / -mere	marshland, lake	Windermere
-fell / -mount	hill, mountain	Scafell
-holme / -holm	island, water meadow	Stockholm

Reference: Nordic/Scandinavian Place Name Patterns

Good for cold, northern, Viking-inspired settings. Old Norse roots appear in many English place names too.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-by	farm, settlement	Whitby, Grimsby
-vik / -wick	bay, inlet	Reykjavik, Lerwick
-fjord / -firth	long narrow inlet	Sognefjord
-heim / -hem	home, world	Trondheim
-berg / -borg	mountain / fortress	Gothenburg
-dal / -dalen	valley	Gudvangen
-ness / -nes	headland, promontory	Skagen
-stad / -sted	place, site	Halstead
-land	land, territory	Iceland, Gotland
-thwaite	clearing, meadow	Braithwaite

Reference: Celtic/Welsh Place Name Patterns

Good for mystical, ancient, fae-adjacent settings. Celtic names often describe landscape features poetically.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Aber-	river mouth	Aberdeen, Aberystwyth
Caer- / Car-	fort, stronghold	Caernarfon, Cardiff
Llan-	church, sacred enclosure	Llandudno
Pen-	head, top, end	Penrith, Penzance
Tre- / Tref-	homestead, town	Tremaine
Dun- / Din-	hill fort	Edinburgh (Dun Edin)
-combe / -cwm	valley	Ilfracombe
Glyn- / Glen-	valley	Glencoe

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Loch- / Lough-	lake	Lochaber
Inver- / Innis-	river mouth / island	Inverness

Reference: Slavic Place Name Patterns

Good for Eastern European-inspired settings. Slavic names often use descriptive compounds.

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLE
-grad / -gorod	city, fortified place	Belgrade, Novgorod
-ov / -ova / -ovo	belonging to (possessive)	Sarajevo, Krakow
Novo- / Novy-	new	Novosibirsk
Staro- / Stary-	old	Starograd
-pol / -pole	field	Sevastopol
Belo- / Byelo-	white	Belgrade (Beograd)
Cerno- / Chern-	black	Chernobyl
-ice / -itz	place suffix	Katowice
-sk / -sko	place/region suffix	Gdansk, Minsk
Veliko- / Veliky-	great, large	Veliky Novgorod

Your World's Place Name Patterns

Create prefixes and suffixes that fit your world's languages. What sounds right for this culture?

PREFIX/SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE IN YOUR WORLD
<i>Kel- / -kel</i>	<i>silver, moonlight</i>	<i>Kelvareth (Silver City)</i>

PREFIX/SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE IN YOUR WORLD

Name your key locations

Use the patterns above (or your own) to name the places that matter most. If you already have names, write them here and note what they mean or evoke.

LOCATION	NAME	WHAT IT MEANS/ EVOKES	NAMING CONVENTION IT FOLLOWS
<i>Protagonist's homeland</i>	<i>Caerwyn</i>	<i>Fortress of the white river — Celtic roots signal ancient, mystical culture</i>	<i>Welsh: Caer- (fort) + gwyn (white/blessed)</i>
Protagonist's homeland			
Love interest's homeland			
The place they meet			
The contested territory			
Their "place"			

Do your characters' naming conventions signal cultural distance?

If your characters come from different cultures, distinct naming patterns instantly tell readers “these people are not the same.” Would someone from Kingdom A struggle to pronounce names from Kingdom B?

YOUR ANSWER

Where could naming differences create a quiet intimacy beat?

A character stumbling over an unfamiliar name, asking what a place name means, or learning that their love interest's homeland translates to something beautiful — these are small moments that build closeness. Where in your story could the act of learning someone's language or place names become a romantic gesture?

YOUR ANSWER

Resources & Territorial Control

Geography tells us who has what and thus who has the ability to have power. Fertile land, fresh water, mineral deposits, trade routes: all of these are valuable enough to fight wars over, to marry for, to die for.

Resource control is probably the most consistent engine for romantic conflict within romantasy. It's behind an arranged marriage to secure a trade route, the tribute that a king demands from a conquered kingdom, the alliance sealed by sending a princess to a court she despises. But resource control does not have to be limited to kingdoms and their battles over land and resources. A character who finds out that their kingdom has been exploiting their love interest's homeland, or who has a monopoly on the one resource that the other's people desperately need. When there is an imbalance of resources there is also a perceived imbalance of power, which is why this works so well.

The most effective way to demonstrate resource control on the page is to show what your characters can and cannot do, rather than telling them through exposition. For instance, a character from a land that has very little water may flinch every time they see someone leaving a tub of water running. If there is a war for control of a particular piece of land because of its strategic location for trade, then someone who is aware of this will notice the strategic advantage where others just view it as beautiful. This awareness should show itself through small reactions, casual conversations about prices or lack thereof, and the constant underlying anxiety that people in this world experience about resources. The tension that develops between two characters when one comes from a side of the battle for resources and the other comes from the opposing side will always develop in their assumptions about each other, what they choose not to comment about, and the times when privilege becomes visible.

Resources & Territorial Control

Reference: Natural Resource Ideas

Use this list for inspiration when filling out the table below.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Precious Metals	Gold, silver, copper, iron ore, bronze, platinum, mithril

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Gems & Stones	Diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, pearls, amber, jade, obsidian, marble, quality building stone
Textiles	Silk, wool, linen, cotton, rare furs, leather, spider-silk, feathers
Food & Agriculture	Grain, rice, olives, wine/grapes, sugar, honey, salt, spices, rare fruits, chocolate/cacao
Animal Products	Ivory, bone, whale oil, animal fat, beeswax, dyes from shells (Tyrian purple), ambergris
Plant Products	Timber, herbs, medicinal plants, rare flowers, resins, incense, tea, coffee, tobacco, opium
Fuel & Energy	Coal, oil, charcoal, peat, magical crystals, dragon-fire, captured lightning
Magical Resources	Ley line access, enchanted springs, magical creatures, spell components, phoenix feathers, dragon scales
Curiosities	Fossils, adder stones, meteoric iron, ancient artifacts, bottled starlight, tears of gods

What natural resources are geographically concentrated?

Think beyond the obvious. What does this world have that ours doesn't? What scarcity shapes daily life?

RESOURCE	WHERE IT'S FOUND	WHO CONTROLS IT
<i>Fertile farmland</i>	<i>River valley between the two kingdoms</i>	<i>Contested — marriage alliance proposed to end the conflict</i>
Fertile farmland		
Fresh water		
Timber/forests		
Mineral deposits		
Coastal access/ports		
Mountain passes		

RESOURCE	WHERE IT'S FOUND	WHO CONTROLS IT
Magical resources		

What geographic resource creates tension or conflict in your world?

Water rights? Arable land? Trade routes? Does the conflict show up as war, political marriage, trade embargo, or something subtler?

YOUR ANSWER

How does geographic resource control affect your characters?

Does one character's family/nation control something the other's needs? Is there territorial dispute between their peoples?

YOUR ANSWER

Continue in Section 4

Resources & Scarcity You've mapped where resources are found and who controls them. In *Section 4: Resources & Scarcity*, you'll explore how resource control creates economic stakes, cultural traditions, and romantic tension.

The Sensory World

Geography doesn't just mean what exists in space; it also means how it feels to be in that space. Those sensory elements of your setting contribute to the emotional texture of scenes. A first kiss will have a different quality to it when done in a garden filled with the scent of night-blooming jasmine as opposed to a stone hallway with torch smoke.

You want to filter the sensory details you are including through your POV character's emotional state. A person in love will notice the warmth of sun on their skin, the sweet fragrance of flowers, and the softness of the grass beneath them. On the other hand, a grieving character will see the same garden as being too light, the flower fragrance overpowering, and the bird song annoyingly loud. Do not attempt to include every detail of a scene. Choose two or three sensory elements that help to establish the mood of each scene you write and then let the rest fade away.

Something to be aware of is the "weather report" style of beginning a scene. This is when you describe your setting using neutral language before anything has happened. By incorporating the sensory elements into the action and emotions of your characters, you will create a stronger scene. Instead of saying "The room was

cold,” say “She tightened her cloak around her body, breath misting in the unheated chamber.” As a character interacts with the world, the way they interact with it creates both the setting of the scene and the feelings of the character simultaneously.

The Sensory World

What does your primary setting look, sound, smell, and feel like?

Close your eyes and walk through this place. What hits your senses first? What would your protagonist notice?

SENSE	DESCRIPTION
What you see	
What you hear	
What you smell	
What the air feels like (temperature, humidity, wind)	

How does the environment change at different times of day?

Dawn meetings feel different than midnight ones. What time of day would be most romantic here? Most dangerous?

TIME	DESCRIPTION	WHAT KIND OF ROMANTIC SCENE WOULD FIT HERE?
Morning		
Midday		
Evening		
Night		

What's beautiful about this place?

The details a character falling in love would notice. What would make someone homesick for this place?

YOUR ANSWER

What's harsh or uncomfortable about this place?

What do people endure or complain about? What takes getting used to?

YOUR ANSWER

Climate, Weather & Seasons

The weather is a form of immediate, physical, environmental condition, which affects everything from how people move through the world, their ability to grow food, warfare, and their day-to-day lives. In addition to providing these barriers to possibility, seasons can provide a deadline (marry before the snow blocks the pass) or a waiting period (trapped together until the spring thaw), or simply mark the passage of time as they navigate their long-term attraction to one another.

Using seasonal events to show the passage of time is a nice way to avoid stating the obvious. The first frost. The smell of rain after months of drought. The way the angle of the sun changes every week. Weather is most effective in romantic stories when it creates some kind of immediate physical problem that both characters have to deal with together: wet clothes that need to come off, cold that needs to be warmed, heat that irritates. Do not simply tell the reader about the weather. Have the characters react to it, complain about it, make decisions based on it.

In addition, seasonal changes can also reflect changes in emotions beautifully. A couple whose relationship begins to thaw as the last of winter melts away. Tensions that build as the temperatures rise with summer. A reckoning that arrives with autumn.

Climate, Weather & Seasons

What's the overall climate?

Climate shapes daily life, which shapes your characters' interactions. Tropical heat, bitter cold, endless rain — each creates different physical problems that your characters may need to solve together.

YOUR ANSWER

What seasons exist and how distinct are they?

Traditional four seasons? A long winter and brief summer? Magical seasons tied to something other than the sun?

YOUR ANSWER

What season is your story set in?

Seasons create mood and constraint. What does this season make possible for your romance? What does it prevent?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Season	
What this season makes possible	
What this season makes impossible	

How do seasons affect life in your world?

When can armies march? When do ships sail? When are weddings held? When must everyone stay indoors?

SEASON	WHAT'S POSSIBLE	WHAT'S IMPOSSIBLE
Summer/warm season		
Winter/cold season		
Transitional seasons		

Does the season create pressure or opportunity in your story?

Racing against winter? Waiting for spring thaw? Only able to travel in summer?

YOUR ANSWER

Dangerous Regions

Every world has places that are deadly, and therefore avoided, or crossed only with preparation and company. Dangerous regions serve romance by raising stakes and forcing partnership. When two characters find themselves needing to travel across hostile territory together, survival becomes the only priority, and the walls people maintain in civilised settings collapse fast.

But the danger has to land. If your characters trek through the Deadly Wastes and emerge fine, readers stop believing the world is dangerous, and if they don't believe the danger, they don't believe your characters need each other to survive it. So let the environment cause damage to your characters: exhaustion, injury, rationed supplies, wrong turns, real fear. Write one character's competence saving the other. Write one character's vulnerability forcing the other to step up. What occurs after your characters survive some horrible event together forever changes their relationship, so make sure you give that shift room to breathe on the page.

Creating the decision to venture into dangerous territory as a heavy decision prior to entering helps too. Characters arguing about whether to go, preparing inadequately, or being forced in against their will. The region itself should have a reputation that precedes it: local guides who refuse to help, maps that end at the border, warnings ignored out of desperation. All of that builds dread, and dread makes the romance that blooms inside the danger feel earned.

Dangerous Regions

What regions are dangerous or forbidden?

Every world has places people warn you not to go. What makes them deadly? What would force your characters there anyway?

REGION	WHAT MAKES IT DANGEROUS	WHO GOES THERE ANYWAY (AND WHY)
<i>The Blighted Wastes</i>	<i>Corrupted magic, monsters, no water for miles, disorienting mists</i>	<i>Exiles, desperate smugglers, and our protagonists who must cross it to reach sanctuary</i>

REGION	WHAT MAKES IT DANGEROUS	WHO GOES THERE ANYWAY (AND WHY)

Do your characters travel through dangerous territory?

Shared danger bonds people fast. What threats would force them to rely on each other?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Where they go and why	
What dangers they face	
What damage the environment causes (exhaustion, injury, rationing)	
What forces them to rely on each other	
What changes between them after surviving it	

Borders & Boundaries

Borders convert geographic areas to identities. When a mountain range or river is defined as the “line” that separates two groups of people, the people on either side begin to define themselves relative to one another. The creation of a border creates cultural assumptions, political tension, and a kind of deep-seated distrust that leads to cross-border romance feeling like something that is strictly prohibited, as opposed to merely inconvenient.

The strongest borders in romantasy are not necessarily lines on a map; they are lines in the minds of the characters. A character raised with the idea that all of the people on the other side of the mountains are barbarians or that no one from the other court can be trusted will have that border inside of them long after the physical one has been crossed. When writing the prejudices that each character holds against the other, make sure they are specific and casual: the assumptions each character makes about the other’s food, manners, values, intelligence. Then write the moments when those assumptions break down.

Also consider the cost of crossing a border for each character. Is crossing considered treason? Social death? Does one character risk everything to cross over while the other side doesn’t even notice? The asymmetry of the cost of the border to each character can lead to the entire romantic arc. Borders can also create “in-between” space: the neutral zone, the disputed land, the meeting point where neither character is quite at home. Many of the most truthful conversations occur in these in-between zones because neither party has the comfort of home base.

Borders & Boundaries

What geographic features create borders?

Mountains, rivers, and oceans don’t just separate land — they separate peoples, and the assumptions each side makes about the other. The feature you choose shapes how crossable the border feels.

YOUR ANSWER

How permeable are these borders?

A border that's easy to cross creates a different kind of forbidden love than one that's physically impassable.

The harder the crossing, the more it costs — and the more that cost means when someone pays it.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters come from opposite sides of a significant border?

Borders create “us” and “them.” What assumptions would each character have about someone from the other side?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What separates them	
What crossing means (legally, socially, personally)	
What “in-between” space exists (neutral zone, disputed land, meeting point)	

What assumptions does each character carry about the other side?

The strongest borders are internal. What does each character believe — casually, without thinking — about people from their love interest’s side? And what moment first cracks that assumption?

CHARACTER	WHAT THEY ASSUME ABOUT "THOSE PEOPLE"	THE MOMENT THAT ASSUMPTION BREAKS
Protagonist	<i>“Night Court fae are manipulative and cruel — everyone knows their High Lord tortured people Under the Mountain”</i>	<i>Seeing Rhysand play with children in the streets of Velaris</i>
Protagonist		
Love interest		

Home & Belonging

One of the most emotionally charged concepts of love is “Home”. The characters may have to travel to find love, may choose between the love they want to have and the comfort of “Home”, may learn that “Home” is wherever the other person is, or may discover that choosing this person means exile from everything familiar.

You can convey this through specific sensory elements and details about the location rather than simply stating that the “place” is important to the character. What is the first thing your character reaches for when they’re homesick? Is there a certain smell that takes your character right back to the time and place that made them feel at home? When you write scenes that take place in your character’s home area, allow them to move with complete ease and familiarity; they know which creaking floorboards they’ll hit, which windows won’t open. Then compare and contrast how your character moves through unfamiliar environments. Do they hesitate, do they observe their surroundings carefully, do they appear somewhat unsteady?

The emotional tug-of-war between “where I belong” and “where love is taking me” creates some of romance’s most powerful emotional beats. When a character decides to remain in their lover’s world, or asks their lover to join them in their world, that decision is just as profound as any verbal confession of love.

This idea is central to the entire arc of the ACOTAR series. The Spring Court is a beautiful place; eternal sunshine, flowers, whimsy. However, after Feyre’s experience Under the Mountain, the beauty of the Spring Court transforms into a prison. Tamlin cages her inside the manor’s wards, and the beautiful landscape that used to be so romantic now feels confining. She then arrives at the Night Court and encounters Velaris: a hidden city of starlight built along the Sidra River, and an artists’ quarter known as the Rainbow. The topography of Velaris parallels what Rhysand provides for her emotionally; safety, creative freedom, a place that welcomes her powers rather than fearing them. As Feyre travels from the Spring Court to Velaris, her physical sense of “home” reflects her emotional connection to each location and to each relationship. When the Spring Court feels like a prison, that relationship is dying. When Velaris feels like home, the new love has grown roots. The geography tells the reader where Feyre’s heart is long before she acknowledges it to herself.

Home & Belonging

Where does your protagonist feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they feel most themselves:

YOUR ANSWER

What does home look, smell, sound like to them?

The sensory details that mean “home”:

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest feel at home?

The place that shaped them, where they’re most themselves. How different is it from your protagonist’s home?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character feel like an outsider?

Fish-out-of-water moments reveal character. Where would each feel uncertain, uncomfortable, or judged?

CHARACTER	WHERE THEY FEEL ALIEN
Protagonist	
Love interest	

Entering Each Other's Worlds

When your characters are from different areas, sending one to visit the other's territory is a big deal. There is a certain risk of weakness in inviting someone to enter your home grounds. While your new friend will be seeing your world through their eyes, they'll also notice aspects of your world you've grown so accustomed to you no longer even think about. Both the beauty and the flaws are equally present.

As soon as a character visits their love interest's territory, use their outsider perspective to observe everything around them. What confuses them? What do they find impressive? What do they find unsettling? Their reactions reveal both the world and the character at the same time. Conversely, the "native" character will experience a type of vulnerability of their own. They will be made aware of the poverty they had normalised, the privileges they had never even considered, or the customs which, although perfectly logical to themselves, appear bizarre when articulated out loud.

It is the tiny moments of the everyday experience where we can witness the truest display of intimacy. The love interest instinctively reaching to help the visitor perform a task they are unfamiliar with. The visitor mispronouncing a word that everyone around them understands perfectly well. The native character defending their home against criticisms they secretly agree with. All of these "fish-out-of-water" situations create closeness, because they necessitate explanations, patience and the trust to allow oneself to appear foolish in front of another person.

In *ACOMAF*, when Rhysand takes Feyre to Velaris, he is revealing to her far more than simply the city itself. He is giving her access to the most protected secret he owns. Velaris has been kept hidden from the rest of Prythian for five thousand years. By taking Feyre to Velaris, Rhysand is entrusting her with the one place that displays who he truly is, beyond the cruel persona he presents in almost every other part of his world. The way she reacts to the vibrant street life, the theatres, the music that resonates with what he communicated to her mentally during her confinement; all of it helps to redefine him. The city *is* the confession. The host does not have to say "this is who I really am" as the very geography speaks for him.

This can happen on a much smaller level. In *Bridgerton* (Season 2 / *The Viscount Who Loved Me*), a thunderstorm sends Kate Sharma into the library at Aubrey Hall, Anthony's family estate. She is petrified, cowering under a desk, and Anthony discovers her in his own domain but at a time when the power dynamics of their relationship have entirely broken down. The ancestral library, full of Bridgerton history, becomes a sanctuary where Anthony provides Kate with the quiet comfort of holding her hand and waiting patiently with her until the storm passes. A public area would have required a sense of propriety. A bedroom would have created scandal. At nighttime in the library, they can find a private area without crossing boundaries, and the vulnerability of that moment forever changes the course of their contentious interactions.

Entering Each Other's Worlds

Does one character visit the other's home territory?

Bringing someone home is an act of vulnerability. What would they be proud to show? What would they rather hide?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who visits whose world	
What the visitor notices first (strange, beautiful, uncomfortable)	
What the host is proud of — and what they'd rather hide	
What everyday moment creates unexpected intimacy	

What's the sensory experience of entering unfamiliar territory?

What do they notice first? What's strange? What's beautiful? What's uncomfortable?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the “native” character see their home differently through the visitor's eyes?

Pride? Shame? New appreciation? Defensiveness?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the visitor understand about their partner after seeing where they come from?

Place explains people. What becomes clear about your love interest once you see where they grew up?

YOUR ANSWER

Travel & Distance

Distance lends an air of seriousness. When characters can go anywhere instantly, then being apart has little consequence. If you're travelling for weeks, then every time your characters leave each other, it counts.

Travelling is not a series of boring scenes to get your characters from point A to point B before they hit the next big plot point. It's the place where all your characters' relationships grow. Travel removes the artificial social boundaries we place around our lives and puts us in a position of shared vulnerability: sleeping close enough to touch, being tired and cranky around each other, having to rely on each other to survive or navigate. Your characters will become intimate with each other out of necessity. One person helping to care for another's blisters. Two people sharing body heat to stay warm in the cold camp. The required closeness of a small boat or a narrow trail where two people can't help but brush against one another.

Also, capture the rhythm of the travel. Comfortable silences. Only talking to each other when there's really nothing else to do. How danger brings your characters closer together than safety could ever hope to. And when you write about separation by distance, show the weight of separation by what your characters *can't* do: letters arriving too late, slow news, the pain of not knowing anything about each other. A reunion after a long period of separation hits much harder than a reunion after a short time apart.

In *From Blood and Ash*, the trip through the Blood Forest is where Poppy and Hawke develop as friends and romantic interests. The continuous threat of attack from Craven continually puts them on edge; however, it's the physicality of the journey that takes away Poppy's social role as the Maiden. She can't even ride a horse, so she rides behind him. They eat meals together by the campfire. The informal nature of the trail removes all formalities. As they continue their journey, Hawke begins to treat Poppy as a peer rather than a charge, and she finally reveals to him her deepest secret, her empathic magic, while nursing back to health a dying guard. It's the actual terrain of the road, not the individual conversations, that allows her to transition from sheltered figurehead to someone making her own decisions.

Fourth Wing does the same thing during their flight to Athebyne. Violet and Xaden have to fly together because of the bond between their dragons, and the close proximity of dragonback travel (they are constantly touching, they have to share body heat, no way to create distance mid-flight) tears down the emotional walls they've put up. By the time they reach the outpost, Violet trusts Xaden as a person, not because of his rank at Basgiath. She trusts him because of the things they both endured during the flight to Athebyne.

Travel & Distance

How do people typically travel in your world?

The mode of travel shapes intimacy. Dragonback forces touching. A carriage allows conversation. Walking side by side is different from riding single-file. What does your world’s travel look like — and what proximity does it create?

MODE OF TRAVEL	WHO USES IT	WHAT PROXIMITY DOES IT CREATE?
Dragonback	Riders at Basgiath	Constant physical contact, shared body heat, no way to create distance mid-flight

Travel Time Reference

These are real-world estimates. Feel free to adjust for your world — magic, flying creatures, or difficult terrain will change things.

MODE OF TRAVEL	DISTANCE PER DAY	NOTES
Walking (comfortable pace)	15-20 miles / 25-32 km	Healthy adult with breaks
Forced march	25-30 miles / 40-50 km	Exhausting, not sustainable
Riding (sustainable)	25-35 miles / 40-55 km	One horse, regular rest
Hard ride	40-50 miles / 65-80 km	Tiring the horse
Changing horses (relay)	80-100 miles / 130-160 km	Fresh mounts at stations
Sailing ship (favorable wind)	100-150 miles / 160-240 km	Highly variable
Carriage/wagon	20-30 miles / 32-50 km	Roads required

How long does travel take between key locations?

Distance creates stakes. A week apart feels different than a year. How painful is separation in your world?

ROUTE	TRAVEL TIME
From capital to border	
From one character's home to the other's	
Across the dangerous region	

Do your characters undertake a significant journey?

The road is where walls come down. What would a long journey together reveal about each of them?

ASPECT	DETAILS
From where to where	
How long	
What happens during the journey	

Isolated Locations

Isolation is romance's secret weapon. When characters can't leave, they can't avoid each other, and avoidance is the enemy of romantic development. Isolated settings force confrontation, require cooperation, and create the kind of pressure that transforms reluctant attraction into something undeniable.

It helps to establish early on why leaving isn't an option, and to make that reason feel real and insurmountable. Once that is established, you can then use the confined space to your advantage. Which rooms do all of the characters have access to? How small are the hallways? What common resources require collaboration? Write the claustrophobia alongside the intimacy, because while being isolated may develop an attraction between the two, that attraction may be hidden from the surface due to resentment toward the closeness caused by the isolation.

Have fun with this, too. On a ship, there's nowhere to go after an argument, so you're eating breakfast together whether you like it or not. At an academy, the professor keeps pairing them for sparring practice. In a snowed-

in estate, someone has to share a bed because the guest wing is freezing. The setting should be generating its own little problems. Let it do some of the storytelling work for you.

And remember: when characters finally *could* leave but choose to stay, that choice is a declaration.

Isolated Locations

What isolated locations exist?

Islands, remote estates, mountain fortresses, ships at sea, academies, pocket dimensions:

LOCATION	TYPE	WHY PEOPLE GO	WHY LEAVING IS DIFFICULT
<i>Stormhold Keep</i>	<i>Remote mountain fortress</i>	<i>Political prisoners sent there; protagonist exiled after scandal</i>	<i>Mountain passes are snowed in 8 months/year; magic wards prevent unauthorized departure</i>

LOCATION	TYPE	WHY PEOPLE GO	WHY LEAVING IS DIFFICULT

How does the isolation generate romantic pressure?

Isolation alone isn't enough — it's the logistics of confinement that force intimacy. What about this space means your characters can't avoid each other? Think about shared meals, narrow corridors, mandatory pairings, limited beds, communal bathing, arguments with nowhere to storm off to.

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>What space must they share?</i>	<i>The single hearth room at Stormhold — the only warm room in the fortress during winter</i>
What space must they share?	
What daily routine forces interaction?	
What happens after an argument (where do they go when there's nowhere to go)?	
At what point could they leave — and what does staying mean?	

Geography as Emotional Landscape

The physical world may support, or oppose, the emotional journey that is happening in your story. A romantic encounter would feel very different if it were happening in a sunny field versus a ruined castle. A confession made during a storm would have much greater emotional impact than a confession made while everything was quiet.

The settings you choose can be directly connected to the emotional beats in your story, or they can be deliberately opposite. If you choose to use a setting which is emotionally charged (for example, a first kiss in a threatening location), you will give your story a sense of urgency. The same kiss in a serene garden would convey safety and a sense of choice. Pathetic fallacy can be effective when it is used judiciously: a storm during a confrontation and sunlight breaking through as characters reconcile. Even more subtle, however, is the idea that characters see the same landscape in different ways depending on their emotional state. A person who is in love might see beauty in every rock and tree. A person who is broken-hearted might see the same landscape as empty and unattractive.

Creating “their place” can also be a powerful thing to do. This refers to a location which becomes sacred to the relationship, whether it’s where they first met, first kissed, or where they weathered some kind of disaster together. When characters return to these meaningful locations, the reader should be able to pick up on the emotional resonance without needing to be told why. A single line, something like “She hadn’t been back to the bridge since that night,” can convey a lot of emotional information to the reader, especially if you had previously established that the bridge was a significant location.

Stephenie Meyer, author of *Twilight*, built the entire premise of the book around this principle. She selected the city of Forks, Washington specifically because it is one of the rainiest, cloudiest places in the country. The rain does more than provide atmosphere; it provides the vampires with the ability to live in plain sight, and it is also symbolic of the dreamlike, suspended quality of Bella’s life once she meets Edward. In addition to the rain, the Meadow is another key setting. It is a sunlit clearing within the surrounding forest, the one place where the clouds break and Edward can reveal himself fully to Bella. Over the course of the story, the Meadow becomes a symbolically important location to the relationship. When Edward leaves in *New Moon*, it is described as withered and dying, and the reader understands that the death of the Meadow reflects the state of the romance. The state of the place is an indicator of the health of the love story.

In *Fourth Wing*, the use of emotional geography is taken further. Violet’s lightning and Xaden’s shadows are not simply metaphorical representations of their emotional states, but are actually manifestations of those states. When the intensity of their emotions finally reaches a boiling point, it manifests physically in the destruction of the space around them. Furniture is destroyed, the room shakes. The physical space around

them literally cannot hold the emotional energy of the connection they share. While that's an extreme version of the principle, the craft lesson remains the same. When the world responds to the romance, readers will feel the emotion in their bodies, as opposed to simply understanding the emotion intellectually.



What's the emotional quality of your primary setting?

The emotional quality of a place shapes every scene that happens there. An oppressive setting adds urgency to a first kiss; a serene one implies safety and choice. Does your primary setting feel oppressive, expansive, peaceful, threatening, beautiful, decaying — and how does that quality interact with your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the environment ever mirror or oppose your characters' emotions?

A storm during a confrontation, sunlight breaking through as characters reconcile, a wilting garden reflecting a dying relationship. Where could your setting respond to the emotional beats of your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a location that becomes meaningful to your characters specifically?

A place they return to, a place where something changed, a place that's "theirs":

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
Does your geography create the friction type you identified? (proximity / separation / resource)	
How does geography explain cultural differences? (<i>Reference: Section 3</i>)	
How does geography create or reinforce power structures? (<i>Reference: Section 5</i>)	
How does geography interact with magic? (<i>Reference: Section 8</i>)	
What geographic resource or territory is contested in your world?	

Quick Reference: Geographic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
<i>Key location 1</i>	<i>The Winter Court — where protagonist is hostage and love interest is prince</i>
Key location 1	
Key location 2	
Key location 3	
The contested resource or territory	
The barrier separating peoples or characters	
The dangerous region	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The isolated location	
The significant journey (from → to)	
The place that matters emotionally	
Other:	
Other:	

Map Making (Optional)

You don't need a map. Plenty of great fantasy stories were written without one.

That said, maps can help you keep travel times consistent and visualise where things are in relation to each other. If you decide to make one, let your story's needs guide you. How far is the border your characters are fleeing towards? Is the palace defensible? Where might lovers meet in secret? Build your geography around the situations your plot requires.

Map-Making Tools

Free options unless noted. Search these names online for current links.

- **Inkarnate** Popular fantasy map maker (free tier available)
- **Azgaar's Fantasy Map Generator** Procedural generation with editing
- **Wonderdraft** One-time purchase, professional quality
- **Donjon** Random generators for maps and dungeons
- **World Anvil** Worldbuilding wiki with map tools (subscription)

Map Making: What to Include on Your Map

Consider which of these appear in your world. You don't need all of them.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE LOCATIONS
Geographic features	Mountains, rivers, forests, lakes, coastlines, islands, deserts, swamps, valleys
Political boundaries	Kingdom borders, disputed territories, neutral zones, conquered lands
Cities & settlements	Capitals, port cities, border towns, villages, abandoned settlements
Trade & travel	Major roads, trade routes, mountain passes, river crossings, ports
Fortifications	Castles, walls, watchtowers, military camps, fortresses
Religious sites	Temples, shrines, pilgrimage routes, sacred groves, forbidden places
Magical locations	Ley lines, magical academies, cursed regions, power sources
Story-specific	Where characters meet, where they're forbidden to go, where they flee to



The geography of your world is about much more than where everything is. It's why your characters can't be together easily, and what they'll have to cross, endure, or sacrifice to change that. The mountain range is why two peoples distrust each other. The desert is why whoever controls the oasis controls the trade route. The isolated academy is why two people who would never have spoken are now sharing a corridor. Build geography that explains your world and creates the pressure your romance needs.

SECTION TWO

FLORA, FAUNA & ECOSYSTEMS

The natural world does more than fill your scenery. It feeds your population, clothes them, provides medicine, creates danger, enables trade, and sometimes forges bonds between characters that nothing else could. In romantasy, nature is at its most powerful when it creates situations your characters have to navigate together. The wilderness that demands partnership. The creature that bonds them. The healing herb that requires one to tend the other.

The Wilderness Principle

Nature in romantasy works like a crucible. Strip away civilisation, the social masks, the safe distances, the comfortable routines, and drop two people into a world that doesn't care about their feelings. What's left is survival. And survival demands honesty.

The natural world compresses characters together. Dangerous wilderness requires partnership. Harsh conditions demand shared shelter, shared warmth, shared resources. Predators make travelling alone suicidal. Seasonal pressures trap characters in place or create deadlines they can't ignore. None of this is subtle, and it doesn't need to be. The best nature-driven romantic tension comes from the fact that the wilderness doesn't offer a polite alternative.

In *Fourth Wing*, every element of Basgiath's mountain environment is designed to kill. The Parapet, the Gauntlet, the dragons themselves. Violet and Xaden's romance isn't built on conversation; it's built on tactical cooperation under lethal conditions, where only competence and loyalty matter. The environment strips away political grievance and forces them to actually see each other.

But nature doesn't just apply pressure. It reveals. How characters interact with the natural world shows who they really are in ways dialogue never can. How they treat animals. What they know about survival. Whether they see nature as resource, threat, or home. And it connects. Shared experiences with nature build relationships that social settings can't replicate. Caring for an injured animal together. Surviving a dangerous encounter. One teaching the other to ride, hunt, forage, or track. Witnessing something beautiful or terrifying together.

In *A Court of Silver Flames*, Cassian forces Nesta into a punishment hike through the Oristian mountains, and the physical exhaustion of that terrain breaks down emotional walls she's spent the entire series building. She finally sheds the tears she's been holding back, not because he asks, but because the mountain leaves her nowhere to hide.

Build the ecosystem first. The story will grow from what you've built.

Flora & Fauna in Romantasy

The natural world in your story serves the romance in three ways: as **backdrop** (atmosphere and texture), as **obstacle** (danger, scarcity, survival pressure), or as **connector** (shared experiences, creature bonds, caring for animals together).

Nature’s Romantic Functions

FUNCTION	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
Pressure	Dangerous wilderness, harsh conditions, predators, seasonal deadlines	Forced proximity, mutual dependence, survival bonding
Revelation	How characters treat animals, what they know about survival, comfort in wilderness vs. civilisation	Character depth, attraction through competence, values made visible
Connection	Caring for animals together, shared danger, teaching survival skills, witnessing beauty together	Domestic intimacy, trust-building, shared memory

How does wilderness function in your romance?

The natural world can pressure characters together, reveal who they really are, or connect them through shared experience. Which of these does your story use — and what specific wilderness element creates it?

FUNCTION	THE WILDERNESS ELEMENT IN YOUR STORY	WHAT IT FORCES, REVEALS, OR CREATES BETWEEN YOUR CHARACTERS
<i>Pressure</i>	<i>The Gauntlet — an exposed mountain crossing where two riders must rope together or fall</i>	<i>Violet and Xaden can't maintain emotional distance when they're literally tied to each other at 10,000 feet</i>



How Animals Serve Romance

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The bonded creature	Magical bond creates parallel to romantic bond; creatures' relationship reflects or contrasts with humans'	Dragons in <i>Fourth Wing</i> , familiars
The shared rescue	Characters save an animal together, establishing cooperation and revealing character	Injured horse, orphaned creature
The animal that judges	Pet or mount only likes one character at first, gradually accepting the other as trust builds	Horse that won't let anyone else ride
The teaching moment	One character teaches the other to work with animals, creating intimacy through instruction	Teaching to ride, training a hawk
The animal witness	Pet or mount present during vulnerable moments, normalising intimacy	Horse that's "seen everything"

How Plants & Environment Serve Romance

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The rare ingredient quest	Must find a specific plant, creating journey and shared purpose	Cure for poison, magical component
The poisoning and healing	One character poisoned, other must find cure or nurse them through	Creates vulnerability and care

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	EXAMPLES
The foraging scene	Gathering food together, one teaching the other what's safe	Domestic intimacy in wilderness
The meaningful flower	Plant with symbolic meaning given as gift or appears at significant moment	Culture-specific flower language

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question in this section will apply to your story. **Skip what doesn't fit.**

If your world is Earth-like, you don't need to reinvent the wheel. Focus on what's *different* from the baseline your readers will assume: the magical creatures, the plants with supernatural properties, the ways magic has changed the ecosystem.

Worldbuild for its own sake if you want to! Use the romance connection prompts for brainstorming if they're helpful, or leave them blank.

And if you're not sure whether something matters yet, skip it. You can always come back once your story has taken more shape.

Common Mistakes with Flora & Fauna

Mistake #1: The Decorative Ecosystem

Your world has beautiful forests and exotic creatures, but they never affect anything. Characters travel through wilderness without interacting with it. A world where nature is just scenery feels thin. You're missing opportunities for pressure, revelation, and connection. The wilderness encounter that forces trust. The animal that reveals character. The danger that bonds.

FIX

Make your characters interact with nature. They need to eat, travel through wilderness, face dangers. Pick a few plants or animals and make them matter to the relationship, not just the setting. The opening of *ACOTAR* works precisely because the frozen, starving woods aren't backdrop. Feyre's decision to kill the fae wolf is driven by ecological desperation, and that single act of survival sets the entire romance in motion.

Mistake #2: The Convenient Creature

A magical creature exists solely to bond your characters or give them cool powers. It has no ecology, no behaviour patterns, no existence outside its plot function. Creatures that only exist for plot convenience feel engineered. Readers can sense when an animal is a device rather than a being. The creature bond that parallels the romance only works if the creature feels real.

FIX

Give your creatures lives beyond their plot function. What do they eat? Where do they live? Even bonded creatures should have existence and personality independent of their bonded humans.

Mistake #3: The Bond That Does Everything

A creature bond exists and immediately solves all relationship problems. The dragons chose them, so they're fated! No further relationship development needed. It shortcuts the actual work of the romance. Readers want to see the relationship built, not handed to them by magical creatures.

FIX

Let the bond create circumstances, not feelings. Proximity or shared responsibility, yes, but love, trust, and compatibility still have to be built by the characters themselves. In *Fourth Wing*, Tairn's mating bond with Sgaeyl forces Violet and Xaden into proximity and shared responsibility, but the romantic relationship between them is built through trust, conflict, and choice. The dragons create the circumstance. Not the love.



Flora & Fauna Self-Check

Review what you've built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Decorative Ecosystem: Nature exists in your world but characters never interact with it meaningfully		
Convenient Creature: A creature exists solely to bond characters or give powers, with no ecology or independent life		
Bond That Does Everything: A creature bond creates the romance automatically, skipping the work of building love and trust		

The Ecosystem Foundation

What's the general relationship between people and the natural world in your setting? A world where wilderness is mostly tamed has very different story possibilities than one where civilisation is a fragile island in dangerous nature.

Your world needs its basics before you add magical flora and fauna. An ecosystem is not a bunch of pretty things together. It is a network of relationships. Climate dictates the terrain, terrain dictates what grows, what grows dictates what eats it, what eats it dictates what hunts it. If you pull one thread, the whole web will be altered.

Your world's large scale geographic features, your mountains, oceans, deserts, and forests, create all of the living organisms within those areas. A mountain range separating a populated valley from an ocean is known as a rain shadow: lush and wet on the windward side, dry and sparse on the other. This geographical reality creates the possibility for a kingdom on each side of the mountain with different diets, different wildlife, different daily lives, and different attitudes towards nature. The fact that two characters from opposing sides of the mountain have different relationships with nature represents a rich area of worldbuilding.

Climate can also determine aspects of culture that you may not initially think of. In a cold world, people layer up. People expose their skin only when in close proximity to others. Removing a glove or pushing back a sleeve takes on a significance that it would never have in a warm climate. In a hot climate, bodies are more visible, but the availability of shade and water are highly valued, and the person who knows where the cool spring is has a great deal of power. Consider what is made scarce by your climate and what is made abundant, because scarcity and abundance shape everything from economics to manners to what counts as a romantic gesture.

Inhabitants of your world do not encounter a neutral environment. Instead, the environment directly influences the interactions that occur. A world where winter extends for eight months will offer different possibilities for romance than a world where there is no end to summer. The character from the jungle who finds the tundra to be both frightening and wonderful has a natural journey to take. When two people from different biomes meet on neutral ground, they bring their own ecosystems with them in their instincts, their knowledge, and their bodies.



What's the general relationship between people and nature in your world?

Do people dominate their environment? Live in balance? Struggle against nature? Have they tamed the wild or does wilderness still rule?

YOUR ANSWER

How magical is the natural world?

Completely mundane (magic is separate from nature)? Subtly magical (nature has hidden power)? Overtly magical (magical creatures are common)? Sentient (nature has awareness or will)?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the overall health of the ecosystem?

Thriving? Balanced? Under pressure from civilization? Recovering from past damage? Dying?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your climate shape intimacy and romance?

What's scarce in your world is valuable. What's hidden is intimate. A glove removed in a freezing world means something different from bare skin in a tropical one. How does your world's climate affect what counts as a romantic gesture, a show of trust, or a moment of vulnerability?

CLIMATE ELEMENT	WHAT IT MAKES SCARCE OR INTIMATE	HOW IT COULD AFFECT YOUR ROMANCE
<i>Endless winter</i>	<i>Exposed skin — removing a glove is an act of trust; shared warmth is survival and intimacy at once</i>	<i>The first time she doesn't flinch when he touches her bare hand in the cold is the turning point</i>

Food Chains & Natural Balance

Every ecosystem has a pecking order, and that order shapes what your characters fear. The apex predator of your world determines what makes wilderness travel dangerous, and dangerous travel is one of romantasy's most reliable engines for forced proximity and survival bonding.

Every single ecosystem operates through a food chain. Something eats, something gets eaten, and if you break or add a connection in this chain, it will cause the entire system to react. So as a fantasy author, you may want to ask yourself, “What happens when I mess with my world’s food chain?”

Your world’s largest, most deadly creature is not simply a threat to your characters. It’s also the element of stability that maintains the balance of your world. Eliminate the apex predator and herbivore populations explode, vegetation gets stripped, soil erodes, streams dry up. A world where heroes kill off the final dragon may rejoice for a generation, then face ecological collapse. That’s a story.

And magical predators need magical-scale territory. In order for your dragon to exist in your world, it must have a hunting area of several hundred miles and if it stays in one location, it is going to devour every piece of livestock around it. Therefore, if you are creating a military base such as in *Fourth Wing* and there are a hundred dragons in that outpost, someone has to determine: where does the meat come from? The logistics of having a hundred dragons at one military base can become a major plot point on its own. The dragon-riding nobility may rely on the existence of a farmer and herder class which they have likely never even given a second thought to, and your protagonist could easily find themselves as a member of that class.

If the magic in your world is dependent upon the land (as it is in *ACOTAR*, where the fertility of each court is dependent upon the High Lord’s power), then a weakened or absent ruler doesn’t just create a political vacuum. It creates an ecological one. The crops fail. Animals migrate. The land itself begins to die. This is rich material for romantic fantasy because it connects the romantic relationship to the ultimate survival of the world. The Great Rite in *ACOTAR* makes this explicit: the couple’s union is literally what keeps the land fertile. You don’t have to connect the romantic union in such an obvious way, but tying romantic resolution to ecological health gives the love story stakes that stretch well beyond the emotions of two individuals.



If your world uses Earth-like wildlife, skip most of this — just note magical creatures or significant deviations.

What's at the top of the food chain in various environments?

These predators shape what your characters fear in the wild. Could any of them create danger or forced proximity in your story?

ENVIRONMENT	APEX PREDATOR	HOW IT COULD CREATE DANGER OR PROXIMITY FOR YOUR CHARACTERS
<i>Dense forests</i>	<i>Thornwolves</i>	<i>Hunt in packs; force travellers to shelter together overnight</i>
Forests		
Plains/grasslands		
Mountains		
Water (rivers, lakes, ocean)		

Does the health of your ecosystem connect to your romance?

In some romantasy worlds, the romantic relationship is tied to the land itself — the couple's bond keeps the world fertile, or a broken relationship causes ecological collapse. Even without a direct magical link, environmental stakes can raise the emotional stakes. Does your world have any connection between the natural world's health and your characters' relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

If your world has large magical creatures, what do they eat — and who provides it?

A hundred dragons at one military base require tonnes of meat per week. Someone raises that livestock. The dragon-riding nobility may never have given a second thought to the farming class that sustains them — and your protagonist might be from that class. What hidden dependency exists in your world, and could it create tension between your characters?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>The magical creature</i>	<i>War dragons at Basgiath — each eats a full steer every few days</i>
<i>What they consume and how much</i>	<i>Hundreds of cattle per week, plus wild game from surrounding mountains</i>
<i>Who provides it (and at what cost)</i>	<i>Valley farming towns supply the meat; one bad season and dragons starve or raid villages</i>
<i>Could this dependency create tension between your characters?</i>	<i>Protagonist is from a farming family whose livestock was requisitioned. Love interest is a rider who's never considered where the food comes from.</i>
The magical creature	
What they consume and how much	
Who provides it (and at what cost)	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Could this dependency create tension between your characters?	

Domesticated Animals & Animal Companions

The animals people have tamed shape daily life, economy, and culture. What pulls the ploughs? What provides meat, milk, leather, wool? What do people ride?

But domesticated animals also reveal character. How someone treats their horse, their dog, their cat tells you something that words can't. Animals witness relationships without judgement, and their small acceptances mark relationship progression. There's a reason so many romance readers lose it when the love interest's grumpy horse finally lets the protagonist pet it.

Horses, dogs, livestock, and other domesticated animals are the backbone of daily life in most fantasy worlds. They provide transport, labour, food, companionship, and warfare capability. As well as providing your characters with a means of getting from place to place, these creatures can be used to show the personalities of your characters through how they interact with them.

Many people view a personal horse as a symbol of wealth, similar to the way that people would view a car and a home today. How a character treats their horse tells you everything about how they'll treat people. The rider who talks to their mount, who checks hooves before seeing to their own comfort, who notices when the animal is nervous: that's a character showing tenderness without saying a thing. On the other hand, a rider that treats their horse as nothing more than a tool is giving the reader a clue as to how that character may treat others as well.

A horse that rejects most riders but accepts the love interest is one of the oldest endorsements in romance, and it works because animals respond to energy, not performance. When the temperamental warhorse nickers at the person everyone else finds frightening, readers trust that judgement more than any dialogue could achieve.

The stable is probably the most consistent intimate space in romantasy. Stables are private, physical, domestic. Two people grooming a horse side by side. One holding the reins while the other adjusts the saddle. The smell

of hay and warm animal. Haylofts during rainstorms. These scenes work because animal care strips away social performance. No one can be haughty when cleaning out a stall, and that equality of labour is itself a form of intimacy.

Then there's the shared saddle. Two characters, one horse. There is no denying why this is such a popular trope: the enforced physical contact, the warmth of another body, the rhythm of the horse's movement. If you're using it, know that readers with riding experience will notice if you ignore the practicalities. Saddles are designed for one rider. Riding a horse with two people on board is rarely comfortable and almost always difficult to manoeuvre. But you can lean into the awkwardness, the manoeuvring, the apologies, the "this is ridiculous," and the realism actually makes the scene more charming than pretending it's elegant.

Dogs, hawks, cats, and other working animals add texture and personality to your world too. A war dog bred for battle. A hunting hawk that returns only to one person. A cat that sleeps on the protagonist's manuscript. All these animals give you the opportunity to show the soft side of a hardened character. The fierce warrior who speaks softly to his dog. The cold assassin whose cat sleeps on his chest. Readers eat this up, and it works because the contrast between public persona and private tenderness is exactly what romance runs on.

If your world has dragons, griffins, giant wolves, or other magical mounts, the logistics scale up enormously. A dragon needs to eat, potentially tonnes of meat per week. Where does that food come from? Who supplies it? A kingdom housing hundreds of magical mounts needs an entire agricultural infrastructure just to keep



What animals have been domesticated in your world?

Think about what your protagonist interacts with daily. Which animals reveal character through how people treat them?

PURPOSE	ANIMAL	WHO KEEPS THEM
Transportation	Nightmares (shadow horses)	Only the fae nobility; protagonist's love interest has one named Ember
Meat/food		
Transportation		
Labor/draft work		
Companionship		

PURPOSE	ANIMAL	WHO KEEPS THEM

Are there domesticated magical creatures?

If so, what are they used for and who has access to them?

YOUR ANSWER

Does your protagonist have an animal companion?

How someone treats their animal reveals character. What does this companion show readers about your protagonist?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>Animal</i>	<i>A half-wild cat who only tolerates her — hisses at everyone else</i>
<i>Name</i>	<i>Smoke</i>
<i>What the animal means to them</i>	<i>The only creature that stayed through the lean winters; proof she can be gentle when she chooses</i>
Animal	
Name	
What the animal means to them	

Does your love interest have an animal companion?

Does the animal accept your protagonist? That small moment of acceptance can mark relationship progression.

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>Animal</i>	<i>A massive warhorse that throws anyone who isn't him</i>
<i>Name</i>	<i>Tempest</i>
<i>What the animal means to them</i>	<i>The horse chose him when no one else did. Tempest letting her scratch his nose is the first sign that the love interest's walls are coming down.</i>
Animal	
Name	
What the animal means to them	



Could a stable, shared ride, or animal-care scene create intimacy in your story?
Stables are private, physical, domestic — two people grooming a horse side by side strips away social performance. Sharing a saddle forces contact that neither character can avoid. Where could this kind of animal-adjacent intimacy show up in your story?

SCENARIO	HOW IT COULD PLAY OUT
<i>Shared saddle — one horse, two riders</i>	<i>She has to ride behind him; arms around his waist, her cheek against his back when she's too tired to hold herself upright. Neither mentions it afterwards.</i>



Do your characters encounter wildlife together?

Shared encounters reveal who each person truly is. What might show your protagonist a new side of the love interest?

WHAT THEY ENCOUNTER	HOW THE PROTAGONIST REACTS	HOW THE LOVE INTEREST REACTS	WHAT THIS REVEALS
<i>A wounded deer caught in a snare</i>	<i>Wants to free it immediately — acts on instinct</i>	<i>Checks the surroundings first, identifies the hunter's trail — acts on strategy</i>	<i>She leads with compassion, he leads with caution. Both are right. Neither understands the other yet.</i>

Do your characters care for an animal together?

Shared caregiving builds domestic intimacy and reveals nurturing instincts. What creature might bring them together?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What creature and why it needs care	
What this creates between them	

Agriculture, Wild Plants & Foraging

If your world has Earth-like agriculture, skip the basics and focus on what's unique: magical crops, supernatural plants, or specific foods that matter to your story.

While your romance takes place in a fantasy world, most people in a pre-industrial society still rely heavily upon agriculture as a means of survival. Farming is the basis for everyone's lives, the source of wealth and power, and the driving force behind the class dynamics your romance will navigate. You don't need to become an agronomist, but knowing how food is produced impacts your world and allows you to develop ideas that create depth beyond just scenery.

Seasonal agricultural cycles govern when people work, when they celebrate, when they starve, and when they fight. As spring arrives, communities band together to plant crops. During harvest time, communities put aside social norms: the night when class boundaries blur, when the lord's daughter dances with the stable hand, when a masked stranger turns up and nobody asks questions. When there is not enough to go around during the winter months, families are stuck at home, which creates close living conditions.

Katherine Arden uses winter itself as a character in her novel *The Bear and the Nightingale*. The cold weather brings everyone in the house together around the fireplace and traditions are practised because they help

appease the house spirits. The seasonal cycle of the story is not simply the background. The story is structured by the cycle of the seasons.

If the person that owns the farmland in your world has control over that land, then that individual holds enormous power. In a feudal system, the peasants are bound to the land owned by the nobility. In a magical world, the rulers may use magic to produce enormous amounts of food using very little labour, thus displacing the working class and providing them with cause to be resentful. Regardless of the type of world you create, land is power, and the ownership of land creates the class divisions that your romantic leads will either have to overcome, bypass, or overthrow.

One especially valuable tool in this context is the inherited estate. When a character inherits a piece of property, they receive independence, purpose, and a place to live, but also inherit the politics, debts, and neighbours that come with the territory. Conflicts over land provide natural enemies-to-lovers situations: two people who both have a legitimate claim to the same piece of land, forced to negotiate, compete, or collaborate.

When resources are scarce, every available issue can quickly escalate into a major point of contention. Petty lords who intentionally cut off trade routes for spite. A failed harvest that forces an unlikely alliance between sworn enemies. A protagonist who has to marry for grain instead of love. Hunger makes political marriages urgent rather than abstract, and the character who splits their last loaf of bread with a stranger has earned the right to fall in love.

And if mages can grow a season's food in a day, the economy of the world is turned upside down. Less people will be needed to grow the food, and many people will move from rural areas to cities. A new class of displaced workers resents the magical elite. The mages who feed the kingdom hold power that rivals the monarch's. All of this creates romantic tension between characters on opposite sides of that shift: the mage who's never been hungry and the farmer whose livelihood was erased by magic.

Agriculture creates the daily rhythms, class structures, and resource pressures that your romance operates within. The harvest festival scene, the winter storm that traps characters together, the field where two people work side by side and talk about nothing import



What are the staple crops?

The grains, roots, or plants that feed most people:

YOUR ANSWER

What non-food crops are important?

Cloth, medicine, and intoxicants shape daily life. What might your characters wear, use for healing, or drink?

CROP TYPE	SPECIFIC PLANT	WHAT IT'S USED FOR
Fiber (for cloth)		
Medicinal herbs		
Intoxicants		

How does food, land, or agriculture create tension in your romance?

Land is power. Scarcity forces alliances. Harvest festivals blur social boundaries. A character who splits their last loaf of bread with a stranger has earned the right to fall in love. What agricultural reality puts pressure on your characters' relationship?

AGRICULTURAL ELEMENT	HOW IT AFFECTS YOUR ROMANCE
<i>The harvest festival — one night where class boundaries dissolve</i>	<i>It's the only night the lord's daughter could dance with a commoner without scandal. By morning, the rules return — but the memory doesn't.</i>



It is obvious what type of place someone has lived based on their knowledge of wild plants. The love interest who identifies safe berries without hesitation has spent time living in the wild. The sheltered protagonist

who can't tell an edible root from a poisonous one has been protected from the world's rougher edges. The difference in knowledge is a difference in experience, and gaps in experience are where romantic tension lives.

When two characters are in the wild and one of them starts gathering food where the other sees only weeds, the power dynamic shifts. The "powerful" character who's helpless without a kitchen is suddenly dependent on the "ordinary" character who knows which mushrooms won't kill them. That reversal, the competent becoming vulnerable, the overlooked becoming essential, is a classic romantasy move, and foraging is perhaps the most natural way to achieve it.

In Juliet Marillier's *Daughter of the Forest*, Sorcha's knowledge of plants is both her profession and her means of survival. She lives alone in the forest, foraging and healing, while observing a vow of silence. Her expertise with herbs isn't a hobby. It's the thing that keeps her alive and defines who she is. If a writer takes the same approach as Marillier, using knowledge of wild plants in such detail, then the ability to find and prepare wild plants becomes a form of power that rivals swordplay.

Gathering food together is also a slow, sensory, physically close activity. One character showing the other how to dig up a root, how to strip bark, how to tell ripe from unripe. In many cases, it requires physical contact. One person demonstrates with their hands. Their fingers brush against leaves. The teaching dynamic naturally collapses distance, and the shared focus on a task gives nervous characters something to do with their hands and eyes while emotional walls come down quietly.

Every forager knows that the most beautiful things in the forest are often the most dangerous, too. Confusing a safe plant with a toxic one is easy, since some edible and lethal plants look nearly identical, and a misidentification can mean agony, hallucination, or death. That's useful for your story. The character who's been poisoned needs help. The character who identifies the plant and knows the antidote becomes the hero. The character who poisoned them on purpose is your villain, or your morally complicated love interest.

Identify a few plants that are unique to your world and give them names, appearances, and properties your readers can track. A flower that numbs pain but clouds judgement. A root that heals wounds but tastes like grief. A berry that's safe for fae but lethal for humans. When plants have specific, memorable properties, they become tools you can use again and again throughout your story.

At its core, foraging is domestic intimacy transplanted to the wilderness. Two people finding food together, preparing it, sharing it. One providing for the other through knowledge rather than wealth or strength. That quiet competence, "I can keep you alive out here," is its own form of declaration, and it hits differently than a sword or a spell.



What can be gathered from the wild — and what's dangerous?

What your characters know about wild plants reveals where they've been and how they've survived. A gap in knowledge between your characters is a gap in experience — and that's where romantic tension lives.

PLANT	SAFE OR DANGEROUS	WHO WOULD KNOW THIS (AND WHO WOULDN'T)

Who knows foraging skills?

Rural common knowledge? Specialised profession? Lost art? Class-dependent? Consider whether this creates a knowledge gap between your characters — the one who knows plants holds quiet power over the one who doesn't.

YOUR ANSWER

Could a foraging or plant-knowledge scene build your romance?

One character teaching the other to find food. Fingers brushing over leaves. The “powerful” one suddenly dependent on the “ordinary” one who knows which mushrooms won’t kill them. Could this reversal or intimacy work in your story?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>Which character knows plants?</i>	<i>Sorcha — she’s been foraging alone in the forest for years; it’s the thing that keeps her alive</i>
<i>Which character is out of their depth?</i>	<i>The warrior prince who’s never had to find his own food</i>
<i>What does this knowledge gap reveal about each of them?</i>	<i>Her competence is a quiet form of power he’s never encountered. His helplessness without a kitchen makes him human to her.</i>
Which character knows plants?	
Which character is out of their depth?	
What does this knowledge gap reveal about each of them?	
What intimate moment could foraging create?	

Medicine & Healing

The healing scene is one of the most well-known tropes in romance, and personally it's a favourite. It provides an opportunity for characters to be physically closer to each other, especially when one or both of them aren't comfortable with that idea yet.

When you write a healing scene, slow it down as much as possible. These moments are all about the small physical details: the temperature of the water, the sting of antiseptic, the careful pressure of wrapping a bandage. Let the injured character actually be vulnerable. Not stoic and silent, but hissing at pain, fighting to stay still, embarrassed by their own weakness. The healer's competence is attractive, so let their hands know what to do. One character can't move away. The other has to stay close. Don't rush to dialogue. Let the silence and the physical contact do the work. The intimacy comes from the combination of pain, trust, and gentleness.

In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy's empathic healing abilities create physical intimacy with Casteel that would be impossible within the rigid protocols of her Maiden role. Her magic requires touch, and touch requires trust, and trust is the one thing her world has taught her not to give.

What natural remedies exist?

Healing scenes create intimacy. What would one character use to tend the other's wounds or illness?

AILMENT	REMEDY
Pain	
Fever	
Infection/wounds	

Can you picture a healing scene in your story?

Healing scenes are about trust, vulnerability, and physical closeness. One character can't move away. The other has to stay close. What situation might create this moment between your characters?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>Who's injured or ill?</i>	<i>Violet — wyvern acid burn across her ribs, can't reach it herself</i>
<i>Who does the healing?</i>	<i>Xaden — the only one she'll let close enough to see the wound</i>
<i>Why is this moment intimate (what walls come down)?</i>	<i>She has to remove her armour and let him see her at her most physically vulnerable. He has to be gentle when the world only sees him as dangerous.</i>
Who's injured or ill?	
Who does the healing?	
Why is this moment intimate (what walls come down)?	
What's the small physical detail that carries the emotion?	

Is there a plant that's crucial to your plot?

A cure for a curse? The only antidote to a poison? A rare ingredient for a necessary spell?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The plant	
What it does	
Where it's found	
Why it's hard to obtain	

Dangerous Creatures

A good creature encounter builds in layers. First the signs: tracks, silence, smell. Then the glimpse. Then the full reveal. Let your POV character's body react before their mind catches up. The prickle on the neck, the instinct to freeze.

During the encounter itself, narrow your focus to immediate sensory details. The creature's breath. The sound of its movement. The texture of the ground they're pressed against. And afterwards, don't skip the physical aftermath. The shaking hands. The delayed terror. The way adrenaline crash actually feels.

Shared dangerous encounters bond characters because they've seen each other in survival mode, stripped of social performance. That's not something you can fake or take back.



What are the most dangerous creatures in your world?

Danger forces characters together. What creature might your protagonist and love interest need to survive together?

CREATURE	WHERE FOUND	WHY DANGEROUS
<i>Thornwolves</i>	<i>Dense forests between the kingdoms</i>	<i>Hunt in packs, venomous spines, force travelers to seek shelter — creates forced proximity scenes</i>

CREATURE	WHERE FOUND	WHY DANGEROUS

Magical Creatures & Creature Bonds

Magical creatures occupy a different space than mundane wildlife. They might be rare and legendary, or common as horses. They might be intelligent, tameable, or utterly alien. Some of them form magical bonds with humans: dragons, familiars, spirit animals. The creature bond often parallels the romantic bond. Two beings learning to trust each other, communicate, work together.

But creature bonds can shortcut romantic development if you're not careful. The best creature bond romances treat the bond as creating circumstances, proximity, shared responsibility, rather than dictating romantic outcomes.

The moment a bond forms should feel earned, not assigned. The strongest bonding scenes share a structure: crisis, then choice, then fusion. Put the character under extreme pressure, force them to make a decision that reveals their core nature, and let the creature respond to *that*. In *Fourth Wing*, Tairn doesn't bond with Violet because she's powerful. He bonds with her because she risks her life to defend a weaker dragon. Her moral courage, not her combat skill, is what resonates. In *Throne of Glass*, Manon Blackbeak is expected to choose a powerful wyvern mount, but instead she chooses the battered "bait beast" that everyone else dismissed. She sees tactical resilience in a creature the world calls worthless, and that recognition forges a bond deeper than any assignment could.

Once the bond exists, make it sensory. Move beyond simple telepathy. Let the character feel the weight of the creature's mind pressing against theirs, the disorientation of shared senses, the physical toll of channelling power they weren't built to hold. The bond should feel like gaining a second nervous system: extraordinary, overwhelming, and occasionally really inconvenient.



Reference: Fantasy Creature Ideas

Use this list for inspiration. Mix and match, or create something entirely new.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Flying Creatures	Dragons, wyverns, griffins, phoenixes, rocs, pegasi, hippogriffs, thunderbirds, harpies
Shapeshifters	Werewolves, werecats, skinwalkers, selkies, kitsune, tanuki, doppelgangers, mimics
Aquatic	Merfolk, sea serpents, krakens, sirens, kelpies, selkies, leviathans, water horses, naiads
Forest & Nature	Unicorns, treants, dryads, will-o'-wisps, sprites, satyrs, centaurs, giant spiders, dire wolves
Undead & Dark	Vampires, wraiths, banshees, revenants, liches, specters, ghouls, wights, death hounds
Elemental	Fire salamanders, ice wyrms, earth golems, storm spirits, magma beasts, frost giants, djinn
Fae & Spirits	Pixies, brownies, redcaps, bogarts, pucks, changelings, banshees, will-o'-wisps, sluagh
Chimeric & Hybrid	Chimeras, manticores, sphinxes, cockatrices, basilisks, hydras, perytons, owlbears
Bonded/Familiar Types	Ravens, cats, owls, snakes, foxes, wolves, small dragons, fire lizards, shadow hounds
Giant Versions	Giant eagles, dire bears, mammoth wolves, enormous boars, colossal serpents, titanic stags

What magical creatures exist in your world?

Consider creatures that might bond with characters, serve as obstacles, or hold symbolic meaning in your story.

CREATURE	INTELLIGENCE	MAGICAL ABILITIES	RELATIONSHIP WITH HUMANS
<i>Phoenix</i>	<i>High — can communicate through emotion/images</i>	<i>Fire magic, rebirth from ashes, healing tears</i>	<i>Bond with fire mages; protagonist bonds with one, linking her to love interest's court</i>

CREATURE	INTELLIGENCE	MAGICAL ABILITIES	RELATIONSHIP WITH HUMANS

How common or rare are magical creatures?

Everyday occurrence? Regional? Nearly mythical?

YOUR ANSWER

How do magical creatures fit into the ecosystem?

Do they fill normal ecological roles? Exist outside natural laws? Disrupt normal nature?

YOUR ANSWER



Do any creatures in your world bond with humans?

If no, skip to the next section.

YOUR ANSWER

How does the bond form?

The strongest bonding scenes share a structure: crisis, then choice, then fusion. Tairn bonds with Violet because she risks her life to defend a weaker dragon. Manon chooses the battered “bait beast” everyone dismissed. What crisis and choice could trigger the bond in your story?

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS IN YOUR STORY
<i>The crisis</i>	<i>Violet is cornered on the Parapet with no weapon and a dying classmate</i>
<i>The choice that reveals character</i>	<i>She shields the weaker dragon with her own body — moral courage, not combat skill</i>
<i>The bond forms because...</i>	<i>Tairn responds to who she is, not what she can do</i>
The crisis	
The choice that reveals character	
The bond forms because...	

What does the bond provide?

Communication? Shared senses? Telepathy? Empathic connection? Shared magic? Extended lifespan?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the bond cost or demand?

Responsibility? Shared pain? Shortened human lifespan? Behavioral changes?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters have bonded creatures?

Bonded creatures create shared responsibility and parallel romantic bonds. How might these relationships mirror or contrast with the romance?

ASPECT	PROTAGONIST	LOVE INTEREST
Creature type		
Name		
Nature of bond		

If both characters have bonded creatures, how do the creatures relate to each other?

Do the creatures reflect the romantic tension? Mirror the relationship’s progression? Create obstacles or opportunities for the characters?

YOUR ANSWER

Could the characters have the creature bond without having a romantic relationship?

Are there bonded rider pairs who aren’t romantically involved? Is romance a separate thing from creature partnership?

YOUR ANSWER

Weather, Seasons & Environmental Pressure

Weather and seasons aren't just atmosphere. They're engines. A blizzard doesn't just look dramatic; it removes every option except shared warmth. A harvest festival doesn't just provide a pretty backdrop; it creates a social deadline where vows carry weight and secrets surface. The best romantasy authors treat weather as a character in its own right, something that acts on the protagonists and forces choices they wouldn't otherwise make.

Winter is the classic crucible. Resource scarcity demands communal warmth, and shared shelter strips away titles and duties. The snowed-in cabin, the shared cloak, the single fire. These tropes work because the environment leaves no polite alternative to intimacy. In *Fourth Wing*, the brutal winter training at Basgiath intensifies the physical and psychic connection between Violet and Xaden. When their dragons mate during a snowstorm, the referred sensations drive them into the freezing night, where the only way to manage the psychic bleed-through is to share their most private mental landscapes.

Spring works differently. Where winter compresses, spring reveals. It shows the damage that was hidden beneath the frozen surface. Characters emerging from trauma don't snap back to who they were; they become something new, and that becoming is messy and nonlinear. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre's healing after Under the Mountain mirrors the return of the seasons themselves. Learning to paint again during Starfall. Growing into power she didn't ask for.

Seasonal festivals create social pressure that characters can't avoid. Calanmai in the Spring Court is a fertility ritual that forces Feyre to confront her attraction to Tamlin. Starfall in the Night Court becomes the moment Feyre laughs for the first time since her trauma, while Rhysand watches. These aren't background events. They're pivot points where desire quietly complicates everything.

SEASONAL DEVICE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
Winter scarcity	Blizzard, lack of shelter, dwindling resources	Forced sharing of warmth, food, space; survival bonding
Seasonal festivals	Celebrations with rituals, vows, social expectations	Public pressure, romantic confrontation, secrets surfacing
Spring renewal	Thaw after trauma, first signs of life returning	Emotional vulnerability, tentative hope, messy healing
Dangerous weather	Storms, floods, fog that disorients or traps	Forced proximity, isolation from allies, sensory intensity

SEASONAL DEVICE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
Seasonal deadlines	Harvest before winter, migration, breeding season	Urgency, stakes that can't be postponed, ticking clocks

What seasonal or weather event matters most to your romance?

A blizzard that removes every option except shared warmth. A festival where desire quietly complicates everything. A spring thaw that mirrors messy healing. What weather or seasonal moment will your romance hinge on?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>The weather event or season</i>	<i>Starfall — a night when the stars fall like rain over the Night Court</i>
<i>Where your characters are when it hits</i>	<i>Standing on a balcony together, the first time she's been outdoors since her trauma</i>
<i>What it forces them to do or feel</i>	<i>She laughs for the first time. He watches. Neither of them names what's happening.</i>
The weather event or season	
Where your characters are when it hits	
What it forces them to do or feel	

Symbolism & Cultural Meaning

Cultures attach meaning to plants and animals. Symbols, omens, sacred creatures. A flower given as a gift means more when readers know what it symbolises. But symbolism works best when it's woven in, not announced. Don't have a character explain that ravens mean death. Instead, show a raven landing on the windowsill the morning of the duel, and let the reader feel the chill.

Nature as a Mirror

The natural world can track the emotional arc of your romance if you let it. Barren landscapes during emotional distance. Blooming during vulnerability. Storms during conflict. This technique, sometimes called pathetic fallacy, works because readers instinctively connect weather and mood. But it only lands when the emotion is strong enough to justify it. A gentle disagreement doesn't need a thunderstorm. A soul-shattering betrayal earns one.

In *ACOTAR*, the Spring Court literally blooms as Feyre heals, and decays into winter-like blight when the relationship with Tamlin collapses. The land's health *is* the emotional stakes, made visible. In *Jane Eyre*, Brontë has Jane imagine a December storm in the middle of June when Rochester's secret is revealed. The seasonal reversal mirrors the shock of hope dying in a single moment. These aren't decorative choices. They're structural ones that make the reader feel the emotional shift in their body.

The seasons map naturally onto a relationship arc:

SEASON	RELATIONSHIP STAGE	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Spring	Meeting, infatuation, first vulnerability	Budding, uncertain, fragile, full of potential
Summer	Peak connection, passion, commitment	Warm, expansive, vivid, almost too good to last
Autumn	Conflict, cooling, first real fractures	Fading, bittersweet, beautiful but dying
Winter	Crisis, separation, or transformation	Stripped bare, honest, survival-mode, potential for rebirth

You don't need to follow this literally, and subverting it can be powerful. A romance that blooms in deep winter. A betrayal during a perfect summer day. But knowing the pattern gives you something to play with or push against.

A few things to keep in mind when you're using environment to mirror emotion:

Let the POV character's perception do the work. A character who loves storms will describe rain differently from one who fears them. The same weather can mean comfort or threat depending on whose eyes you're writing through.

Match the intensity to the stakes. A light drizzle for a moment of doubt. A hurricane for the scene where everything falls apart. If every scene gets dramatic weather, none of it lands.

And don't announce the connection. "The rain matched her sadness" kills the effect. "She stood in the downpour until her fingers went numb" lets the reader feel it without being told.



Could the natural world mirror a key emotional moment in your romance?

The best environmental mirroring feels inevitable, not forced. Pick your story's most emotionally intense moment and consider what the natural world could be doing around your characters — not to explain the emotion, but to make the reader feel it in their body.

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>The emotional moment</i>	<i>Feyre learns the truth about Tamlin's bargain — hope dying in a single instant</i>
<i>What the environment is doing</i>	<i>The Spring Court, which had been blooming as she healed, goes still. Petals stop falling mid-air.</i>
<i>Why this works (what it makes the reader feel)</i>	<i>The reader sees the relationship's death made visible in the landscape before either character says a word</i>
The emotional moment	
What the environment is doing	
Why this works (what it makes the reader feel)	



What creatures have symbolic meaning in your culture?

Symbols add layers to scenes without a word of dialogue. A raven landing on the windowsill the morning of the duel. A white stag appearing the night before a proposal. What creature might appear at a significant romantic moment, and what would it mean?

ASSOCIATION	CREATURE	HOW YOU COULD USE IT IN A SCENE
Death	Ravens	<i>A raven lands on the windowsill the morning of the duel. Neither character mentions it. The reader feels the chill.</i>
Love		
Death		
Royalty/power		
Luck (good or bad)		

What plants have symbolic meaning?

Symbols add layers to scenes without a word of dialogue. A flower given as a gift, a tree that blooms out of season, a herb burnt at a funeral. What plants carry meaning in your world, and how might you use them in a scene?

PLANT	WHAT IT SYMBOLISES	HOW YOU COULD USE IT IN A SCENE
<i>Nightbloom (a flower that opens only in darkness)</i>	<i>Love that thrives in secret, hidden desire</i>	<i>He leaves one on her pillow the night before she's betrothed to someone else. She presses it in a book. Neither of them mentions it.</i>

Integration Check

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
How do plants and animals enable or restrict magic? <i>(Reference: Section 8)</i>	
Does control of creatures or natural resources create political or economic power? <i>(Reference: Sections 4-5)</i>	
How have creatures or environmental factors shaped history? <i>(Reference: Section 7)</i>	
Do weather patterns or seasonal cycles create festivals, deadlines, or forced proximity that affects the romance? <i>(Reference: Section 6)</i>	

Quick Reference: Flora & Fauna Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Staple food source	
Most valuable natural resource	
The dangerous creature	
The bonded creature (if applicable)	
The ordinary animal companion	
The crucial plant (medicinal, magical, or plot-relevant)	
Environmental challenge or threat	

— ◆ —

You don't need a biology textbook. But you do need to know what people eat, what they fear in the wilderness, what animals they work with, and what plants heal or harm them. This foundation makes everything else feel real. Build the world first. Find the story in what you've built.

Section 2 · Supplement: Inter-Species Romance

When your love interests aren't the same species, whether that's human and fae, mortal and immortal, shifter and non-shifter, vampire and living, the worldbuilding itself becomes the obstacle.

Biology, lifespan, instinct, and fundamental ways of experiencing existence create barriers that can't be talked through or wished away.

The Core Question *What does it mean to love someone whose body, mind, or experience of time is fundamentally unlike your own?*

Inter-species dynamics do three crucial things in romantasy. They create obstacles that seem genuinely insurmountable, not misunderstandings that a conversation could fix, but real incompatibilities requiring sacrifice or transformation. They externalise internal conflict, turning the “monster” love interest's struggle with their nature into something visible, physical, and unavoidable. And they raise the stakes on commitment, because choosing each other may mean giving up their own kind, their lifespan, or their fundamental nature.

The key is making species difference *matter*. Not just aesthetically, but in ways that create genuine tension and require genuine choice.

Common Mistakes with Inter-Species Romance

Mistake #1: The Decorative Difference

Your non-human character has pointed ears, enhanced senses, or lives for centuries, but none of it actually affects the relationship. They integrate seamlessly into human life. The fae partner adjusts instantly to mortal customs. The shifter's predator instincts never cause real friction. Species difference is aesthetic rather than functional. If the differences don't create genuine obstacles, they're just costumes. Readers who pick up an inter-species romance want to feel the gap between two fundamentally different ways of existing. When that gap gets smoothed over, the stakes evaporate. Why does it matter that he's fae if he behaves exactly like a human boyfriend?

FIX

Make the differences inconvenient, uncomfortable, and occasionally frightening. How does a human partner cope with a lover who can hear their heartbeat spike during an argument? What happens when the shifter's territorial instincts flare in a crowded room? Show the daily friction of sharing a life across a species divide. Not just the dramatic moments, but the small, accumulating strangeness of it.

Mistake #2: The Instantly Tame Monster

Your vampire, beast, or fae with inhuman morality is presented as dangerous in backstory but never actually threatens the protagonist. The predator instincts vanish the moment the romance begins. The monster is effectively defanged by love. The appeal of monster romance is the tension between what the character *could* do and what they *choose* not to. If there's no real danger, there's no real restraint, and restraint is where the erotic tension lives. Readers notice when a supposedly lethal creature feels perfectly safe. And they're disappointed.

FIX

Love doesn't cure being a predator. Let your monster remain dangerous after falling in love, and show the cost of control within the relationship. The grip that's slightly too tight. The moment they have to leave the room. The partner who notices and understands what's being held back. In *Twilight*, Edward's perspective in *Midnight Sun* reveals that Bella was in genuine danger every moment. The romance only works because readers believe the threat is real.

Mistake #3: The Lifespan Handwave

One partner is immortal (or lives for centuries) and the other is human, but the story never meaningfully grapples with what this means. The age gap is mentioned once and then ignored. The mortal partner's eventual death isn't treated as a source of real grief or tension. A five-hundred-year-old falling for a twenty-year-old creates a power imbalance that readers feel even when the text doesn't acknowledge it. If the immortal partner has centuries of experience, political knowledge, and accumulated power, and the mortal has none of that, ignoring the gap makes the relationship feel unexamined rather than romantic.

FIX

Let the characters discuss it. Let it cause real conflict. Does the mortal feel insignificant? Does the immortal fear the grief of outliving another lover? Is there a way to change it, and if so, what does that transformation cost? The lifespan question should be a source of ongoing tension, not a worldbuilding detail that gets one line and then disappears.

Inter-Species Romance Self-Check

Review the inter-species dynamics you've built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Decorative Difference: Species differences exist but don't create real obstacles in the relationship		
Instantly Tame Monster: Non-human character is described as dangerous but never actually threatens the protagonist or struggles with control		
Lifespan Handwave: One partner will outlive the other by centuries, but the story never meaningfully addresses this		

What Makes Them Different

Biological difference should feel visceral and constant, not something mentioned once and then forgotten. The non-human's different body temperature should be noticeable every time they touch. Their enhanced senses should affect what they notice, what distracts them, what overwhelms them.

The best inter-species romances let the human partner discover these differences through physical proximity. The first time they share a bed and realise the other doesn't breathe while sleeping. The moment they notice

their partner hasn't eaten in days. Let both characters be curious about each other's bodies without it being purely sexual. The intimacy of "what is your experience of existing?" is its own kind of closeness.



What biological differences exist between your species?

Consider: strength, speed, senses, temperature, diet, sleep patterns, healing, aging, reproduction. These should feel visceral and constant — not mentioned once and then forgotten.

ASPECT	PROTAGONIST	LOVE INTEREST	HOW THIS DIFFERENCE AFFECTS THE RELATIONSHIP
Body temperature	Warm — 37°C	Fae-cold — barely above room temperature	Every time they touch, she flinches. He starts warming his hands before reaching for her.
Physical abilities			
Senses			
Diet / sleep			
Aging / healing			

Are there biological incompatibilities?

Touch that burns? Venom? Pheromones that overwhelm? Blood that's intoxicating or poisonous?

YOUR ANSWER

Senses & Perception

Does one species perceive the world differently?

Heat vision, magical sight, ability to sense emotions, scent-based communication:

YOUR ANSWER

What can one perceive about the other that's normally hidden?

Can the fae see through glamours? Can the shifter smell lies? Can the vampire hear heartbeats quicken?

YOUR ANSWER

Lifespan & Time

One of the most profound differences in inter-species romance is how long each partner will live. A human falling for an immortal faces a fundamentally different future than two humans would, and that difference should feel heavy in the story, not like background information.

One of the major distinctions in the ways humans fall in love with non-humans is the length of time that each will exist. A human in love with an immortal will see a vastly different future from two humans do.

This is not merely a matter to be resolved at the end of a story. The lifespan gap should colour the entire relationship. When an immortal has experienced the birth and death of countless generations of humans, the words “I love you” carry a different value than from someone experiencing only one lifetime. Perhaps the immortal holds back, due to their knowledge of loss. They might love with greater passion, knowing they’ll remember this long after the human partner is gone. Perhaps the immortal is incapable of taking the short lifetime of a human seriously, because what’s one argument when you’ve lived through centuries? That lack of respect for a human partner can be hurtful.

The human partner also carries a heavy burden. The awareness that you are temporary to someone you love. As they age, they are reminded daily of their mortality by physical changes such as wrinkles, grey hair, and slowed bodily functions, visible proof of a countdown their partner doesn’t share. Some characters rage against this. Others find peace in the fact that their lives are so short compared to the long life of their partner. The best writing finds a way to validate both of these perspectives. In *Twilight*, Bella’s motivation for wanting to become a vampire is motivated almost entirely by the realisation that she will turn nineteen while Edward will remain forever seventeen. The difference in ageing is unbearable to her, and something Edward cannot fully comprehend, because he has never had to experience the physical changes of his own ageing.

One of the more intriguing approaches to explore here, however, is to depict your immortal character as emotionally stagnant rather than serene. Someone who has existed for five hundred years has not necessarily used those centuries to grow as a person. Instead, they may have spent the last five hundred years actively avoiding growth because they have always had more time. Maas explores this idea in *ACOTAR*. The immortal fae have had the opportunity over centuries to work through the issues of their past and the political issues of their world, but many of them have chosen not to do so, because urgency is a mortal quality. As such, the mortal protagonist’s short, intense life provides them with a sense of purpose and urgency that the immortal partner has lost. This dynamic, where the mortal teaches the immortal how to live rather than the other way around, flips the traditional power structure and allows the relationship to feel like a mutually beneficial exchange, as opposed to a mentorship.

Avoid saving the question about the lifespan until the climax. Let it reveal itself through smaller moments within the story. An example would be the immortal mentioning a hundred-year old memory, and then catching himself. The human who refuses to look into mirrors. Two characters talking about their future, but “our future” means something completely different to each speaker. This kind of subliminal conflict will create the tension of the story, not the single moment of big dramatic confrontation. And when the “solution” comes, if it does, it should cost something. However, whether that price is transformation, magical life extension, or the acceptance of eventual loss, the reader should feel the weight of that price.

Aragorn and Arwen’s relationship in *The Lord of the Rings* establishes the precedent for why that cost is important. Arwen does not simply decide to marry a mortal. Arwen decides to give up her immortality. She gives up her people, her chance to go to the West. And the story does not allow Arwen’s decision to be made lightly: she outlives Aragorn and dies alone in a land where immortal elves once roamed, now empty and grey. It is because Arwen’s decision was irreversible, and the full weight of that decision did not become apparent until long after the “happy ending,” that the true emotional impact lies. That is the standard your lifespan worldbuilding should aspire to. A decision that has an impact well beyond the last page of the book.



How long does each species typically live?

Lifespan disparity creates profound romantic stakes. How does knowing one will outlive the other shape the relationship?

CHARACTER	SPECIES LIFESPAN
<i>Protagonist</i>	<i>Human — 70-80 years, already 23</i>
<i>Love Interest</i>	<i>Fae — immortal unless killed, currently 847 years old</i>
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

How does the longer-lived character feel about loving someone who will die?

Have they loved mortals before? What happened? Are they terrified of the grief?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the shorter-lived character feel about loving someone who will outlive them?

Do they feel insignificant? Worry about being forgotten? Resent that they'll age while their partner doesn't?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there any way to change this?

Can the mortal become immortal? Can the immortal give up their lifespan? What would either cost?

YOUR ANSWER

Instinct, Biology & Choice

Many non-human species come with instincts, drives, or biological imperatives that humans don't share. These create compelling tension, but they also raise questions about consent and agency that you'll want to think through carefully.

The Agency Question *Can your non-human character choose to act against their instincts? If instinct absolutely controls behaviour, you may have a consent problem. Even the most overwhelming instinct should leave room for choice.*

Many non-human species are characterised by an innate set of instincts, drives, or biological imperatives that humans do not possess. While these create a rich source of conflict and tension, they also raise questions about consent and agency that you will need to think through.

Showing the struggle of the non-human character to override its biological programming is crucial. A non-human character whose instincts pull them towards their partner is only romantic if we see that character making conscious choices to act in ways that honour the other person's autonomy. Write the moment when the character's instinct tells it to "claim," and the character instead says "ask." Show the physical price that the character pays to override their biological programming: the bodily tension that results from holding back, the energy required to remain still, the intentional gentleness of choosing to move slowly, which often requires more strength than yielding would. Have the human partner witness this internal struggle and understand what it represents. In my opinion, the most compelling depiction of this dynamic occurs when the non-human character's self-imposed restraint demonstrates itself to be a manifestation of their love. They want you so badly that their body screams for you to respond, and yet they care enough about you to wait until you come to them voluntarily.

Keep in mind the fine line between "instinct creates tension" and "instinct eliminates consent," though. If your non-human character does not have a choice regarding whether or not they choose differently, if the instinct is absolute and cannot be resisted, then your human partner does not truly have a choice either. Your human partner is being pursued by someone they cannot escape. Even the most all-consuming of instincts should allow your non-human character to leave, even if leaving causes them pain.



What instincts or biological drives does your non-human character have?

Consider: predator instincts, pack dynamics, territorial behaviour, mating drives, protective instincts. Which of these are most likely to create friction with a human partner — either because they're frightening, or because they reveal a vulnerability the character would rather hide?

YOUR ANSWER

How strong are these instincts? Can they be controlled?

Easily overridden? Suppressible but uncomfortable? Overwhelming in certain situations?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your character feel about their instincts?

Do they embrace this part of themselves? Fight it? Feel ashamed? Consider it a gift?

YOUR ANSWER

What does restraint look like in the body?

The romance lives in the gap between what your non-human character could do and what they choose not to. That gap needs to be visible. What physical tells show your character is holding back — and what happens in the moments when control slips?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>The physical tells of control</i>	<i>Edward stops breathing around Bella. His hands fist at his sides. He steps back mid-conversation for no apparent reason.</i>
<i>What the human partner notices (and what they understand about it)</i>	<i>Bella sees the golden eyes darken to black and learns this means hunger, not anger — and that she's the cause.</i>
<i>What happens when control slips</i>	<i>A grip too tight on her arm. A flash of something inhuman when someone else touches her. The room he destroys after she leaves.</i>
The physical tells of control	
What the human partner notices (and what they understand about it)	
What happens when control slips	

Mate Bonds & Biological Destiny

Many shifter and paranormal romances include biological “mate” recognition, where the non-human character’s biology identifies a specific person as their destined partner. It’s a beloved trope, but it creates specific challenges you’ll want to be aware of.

Making Mate Bonds Work

The most satisfying mate bond romances do one or more of these:

☐

The bond creates circumstances, not feelings. They’re drawn together, but love still has to be built.

☐

The bond can be rejected at real cost. Walking away is possible but painful.

☐

Recognition happens after feelings develop. They fall in love first; the mate recognition confirms rather than creates.

☐

The bond is actively unwanted. One or both characters fight it.



What exactly happens biologically when a mate is recognized?

Scent recognition? Immediate pull? Gradual awareness? Physical symptoms?

YOUR ANSWER

Can a mate bond be rejected?

If yes — at what cost? Pain? Illness? Death? Permanent inability to bond with anyone else?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the human partner feel about being biologically “chosen”?

Flattered? Trapped? Skeptical? Resentful that the choice was made for them?

YOUR ANSWER

Design your mate bond

The best mate bonds create circumstances, not feelings. How does yours work — and where does it leave room for the characters to build the actual relationship?

ASPECT	YOUR BOND
<i>Does the bond create feelings or just proximity/awareness?</i>	
<i>Can it be rejected — and at what cost?</i>	
<i>Does recognition happen before or after they fall in love?</i>	
<i>Does either character fight the bond — and why?</i>	

The Monster Question

Many inter-species romances involve a character who is monstrous. Vampires, beasts, fae with inhuman morality, demons. The appeal is the tension between danger and tenderness, between what they could do and what they choose not to do.

The key to writing this well is showing restraint as active effort, not absence of desire. The vampire who doesn't bite isn't just not hungry; they're choosing, constantly, to not do what their body wants. Write the physical tells of control. The jaw clenching. The hands fisting. The deliberate step backward. Let the human partner notice these moments and understand what they mean. The erotic tension in monster romance comes from the gap between capability and action, so show the monster being gentle when they could destroy, careful when they could consume. But don't make restraint easy. The cost of control should be visible, and occasional slips (a grip too tight, a flash of something inhuman in the eyes) remind both characters what's being held back.

Twilight *built an entire romance on this tension. Edward's constant, visible effort not to kill Bella. The clenched jaw, the stopped breathing, the careful distance. Readers could feel what it cost him to be near her, and that cost was the attraction.*

The Domestication Problem

A common criticism of monster romance is that the monster gets “defanged.” Their dangerous nature disappears once they’re in love, which suggests their monstrous qualities were never real in the first place.

Don’t do this. Let your monster remain dangerous after falling in love. Love doesn’t cure being a predator. Show how they manage their dangerous nature within the relationship.



In what way is your non-human character dangerous?

Physically dangerous? Supernaturally dangerous? Morally different? Biologically driven?

YOUR ANSWER

Have they hurt people before?

Not accidentally — deliberately. Have they killed? Hunted? Used their powers to harm?

YOUR ANSWER

Are they currently dangerous to the protagonist?

Could they hurt their partner if they lost control? Is this a real possibility?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your protagonist feel about the danger?

Fear and attraction coexist in monster romance. Does your protagonist find the danger thrilling? Terrifying? Both? Do they understand what's being held back — and does that understanding draw them closer or push them away?

YOUR ANSWER

Living in Two Worlds

Inter-species couples face a practical problem: whose world do they live in? Human society that fears the non-human? Non-human society that looks down on the human?

The most effective way to write this is through the accumulation of small moments rather than dramatic confrontations. The way a shopkeeper's smile freezes. The conversation that stops when they enter a room. The friend who keeps "forgetting" to include them. The questions that are really accusations: "But what do you *eat*?"

Show the exhaustion of navigating hostile spaces, and the relief of spaces where both can exist without performance. Let the "insider" partner sometimes fail to notice what their partner experiences, the blind spot of privilege, and let that failure matter. The tension of living between worlds isn't one big conflict. It's the daily friction of belonging nowhere completely.

The Cruel Prince captures this relentlessly. Jude's life in Faerie is defined by the accumulation of small cruelties, the casual dismissals, the constant reminder that she doesn't belong. The hostility isn't one dramatic moment. It's the texture of every day.



Can your couple live openly in human society?

Is the non-human's nature visible? Would they have to hide? Is there prejudice, fear, laws against them?

YOUR ANSWER

Can your couple live openly in non-human society?

How do other non-humans view humans? As lesser? Prey? Novelty? How would the human partner be treated?

YOUR ANSWER

What do each character’s families/communities think of the relationship?

External opposition raises stakes. Whose disapproval hurts most, and what would each character sacrifice to be together?

CHARACTER	FAMILY/COMMUNITY REACTION
Human	Family horrified — fae killed her brother in the war; they see this as ultimate betrayal
Non-human	Fae court sees humans as pets at best; his interest in a mortal is considered degrading
Human	
Non-human	

Does either character have to choose between their partner and their people?

This choice creates powerful romantic stakes. What would each give up, and does the other want them to make that sacrifice?

YOUR ANSWER

What does daily friction look like for your couple?

The tension of living between worlds isn't one big confrontation — it's the accumulation of small moments. The conversation that stops when they enter. The friend who "forgets" to invite them. What small, recurring frictions would your couple face — and does the "insider" partner always notice?

THE SMALL FRICTION	WHO EXPERIENCES IT	DOES THE OTHER PARTNER NOTICE?
<i>The shopkeeper's smile freezes when she walks in with her fae partner</i>	<i>Both — but he doesn't register it as hostile because he's never had to</i>	<i>No. She doesn't mention it. He buys the bread and doesn't understand why she's quiet afterwards.</i>

Transformation & Change

In many inter-species romances, one character can become like the other. Turned, transformed, or granted immortality. This is one of the biggest decisions in your story, and it deserves real weight.

In so many inter-species romance stories, one of the characters may undergo a change: turned, transformed, or receiving immortality. This represents some of the biggest risks in romance writing, and perhaps the biggest risk of all, that of irrevocable change. Irrevocability creates a question: what would I sacrifice to be with this person? But more significantly: should I need to sacrifice anything to be with this person?

Most likely, the tension leading up to the transformation is going to be more impactful than the actual transformation itself. As the human character weighs the losses of mortality, humanity, family ties, and life in the human world, so the non-human contemplates whether to ask for the transformation, whether to offer it, and if the desire for the human to undergo such a change is selfish. These conversations, as well as the silences, are freighted with monumental romance because they speak directly to the deepest questions of commitment. How much of yourself do you reconfigure in the name of love? When does reconfiguring become erasure?

Do not allow the transformation to be either easy or painless, even if it has been chosen or wanted. The process of becoming something fundamentally different from oneself should, regardless of whether it is a voluntary decision, carry both positive and negative connotations. The first human meal after the transformation that tastes differently. The first time looking into a mirror and seeing the reflection of someone slightly altered. The look of confusion from a family member as they try to recognise the new version of you. Timing is important here as well. If the transformation occurs too quickly then the central tension of the relationship is lost. If the transformation occurs just as the story is ending then it may seem like a hasty solution. It is best to create space for the character to consider the consequences of this decision. Allow the character to grapple with it, argue over it, change their mind, and ultimately make the decision with full awareness of what the outcome will be.

This process should also feel visceral on the page. In *Breaking Dawn*, Bella's transformation is described using the language of fire and burning, the venom converting her cells while she lies motionless, choosing silence to spare Edward the sound of her screaming. That "motionless scream" is haunting because it is an act of love presented as an act of absence. In *ACOTAR*, the language shifts: Feyre is "Made" by the Cauldron, forged rather than consumed. The metaphor used to describe the transformation is significant. If magic in your world is a curse, use metaphors of consumption: fire, venom, devouring. If magic is a gift or an inheritance, use metaphors of construction: forging, weaving, remaking. The metaphor you choose will affect the reader's interpretation of the transformation and whether it reads as violation or ascension.

One thing many authors get wrong is the transformation should not resolve the romance. Instead, the transformation should create complications. The most common misstep is treating the change as the happy ending, as though character transforms, power imbalance resolved, story over. But perhaps the most compelling romantasy stories are those where transformation is merely the start of an array of new problems. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre's transformation into High Fae affords her the right to walk among the fae, but it also makes her a target for fae politics, a receptacle for unstable magic she did not request, and someone whose

physical form has altered irrevocably. Thus, it is Tamlin's failure to recognise this new reality that creates the romantic conflict in *A Court of Mist and Fury*: he continues to treat her as fragile, as if she were still human. The fact that their identities have shifted but their way of relating to one another has not, created a chasm that ultimately broke them. The transformation didn't fix the relationship. It brought the cracks within the relationship to the surface.

Armentrout uses a layered transformation model in *From Blood and Ash*. Poppy's identity is both removed and rebuilt several times throughout the novel, each revelation recalibrating the power dynamic with Casteel. Every time they reach a new level of equality, a new transformation occurs creating yet another imbalance. This continuous rebalancing of power dynamics sustains the romantic tension throughout the entire novel far beyond the initial "will they or won't they," because the question is no longer simply "will they be together?" It's "can they be equal when one of them is constantly transforming?"

Bella's transformation in the *Twilight* saga is the structural element upon which the entire series is based. She desires it from the very beginning. Edward is unwilling to allow her to lose her humanity. Their disagreement, not about whether they love each other, but about the price of that love, fuels books of tension. As such, by the time the transformation finally occurs, it has been so well earned that it feels like a true resolution as opposed to a convenient plot device. And the payoff for this transformation is powerful due to the fact that the power dynamic has flipped: Bella as a newborn vampire possesses a self-control and strength that shocks even the elder vampires, effectively erasing the vulnerability that defined her human arc. What was seen as a weakness, her psychological resilience, her capacity to withstand trauma without breaking, becomes her literal superpower.



Can the human become the non-human's species?

Turned vampire? Made immortal? Given fae blood? Become a shifter?

YOUR ANSWER

What does transformation cost?

Physical (pain, danger of death)? Spiritual (losing their soul)? Social (losing their human connections)?

YOUR ANSWER

Who wants transformation — and who doesn't?

Disagreement about transformation creates tension. Does one want to change and the other resist it? Why? And what are they each afraid of losing?

CHARACTER	DO THEY WANT TRANSFORMATION?	WHY?	WHAT ARE THEY AFRAID OF LOSING?
<i>Bella</i>	<i>Yes — desperately</i>	<i>Can't bear aging while Edward stays 17; wants to be his equal</i>	<i>Charlie, her human life, the possibility of children</i>
<i>Edward</i>	<i>No — refuses to allow it</i>	<i>Believes he'd be damning her soul; can't bear being responsible for her death</i>	<i>Her humanity, which is the thing he loves most about her</i>
Human			
Non-human			

The best inter-species romances don't position the human as "normal" and the non-human as "other." Both have their own valid ways of being. The question isn't "how does the non-human become acceptable?" It's "how do two people with genuinely different natures build something that honours both?"

SECTION THREE

CULTURE, CUSTOMS & DAILY LIFE

Culture is the texture of your world. It's the unwritten rules everyone knows, the rituals that mark important moments, the things people do without thinking about them. How they greet each other, what they eat, what they believe about luck, how they raise their children, and what they do for fun. And in romantasy, culture is the invisible architecture that determines what your characters can and can't do, what it costs them to step out of line, and what hoops they have to jump through to be together.

The “Invisible Cage” Principle

Cultural boundaries create some of the most compelling constraints when they’re so much a part of your character’s world view that they are unseen by themselves. What we call love is what brings these into focus.

A character who has never questioned arranged marriage doesn’t experience it as oppression until they want to marry someone else. A character who assumes certain others are inferior to them does not recognise the limitations of their assumptions until they develop romantic feelings for one of those people. Those bars were always there. It’s when your character wants something on the other side of those bars that they begin to realise there are limits.

Feyre in *ACOTAR* is an excellent illustration of this. She never questions Tamlin’s protective nature or the rules of the Spring Court until she experiences Rhysand’s Night Court, where she’s given autonomy and actual choice. It was only through experiencing love from someone who treats her differently that Feyre realises the cage she has been living in. And the cage she had been living in was not due to Tamlin’s cruelty. It was Feyre genuinely believing that was what love looked like.

What does your character take for granted that love will make them realise?

- **Unquestioned norms:** “This is just how things are done.” Until doing things differently becomes the only way to be with the person they want.
- **Invisible hierarchies:** Differences in status that are normal to the character with the higher status but felt to be oppressive to the other character. The tension exists at the point when the privileged one finally sees it.
- **Internalised shame:** Characters that feel unworthy of love because their culture taught them they are less than others. Their partner will need to battle those feelings along with each external challenge.
- **Loyalty costs:** To choose love is to betray community, family, and tradition. The identity that the character held prior to love will no longer exist; the new identity will be one that their previous self would not recognise. That transformation *is* the story.

The invisible cage works because culture creates identity. Disobeying the law is an action. Defying your culture is an identity crisis. When your characters choose to follow their heart rather than their traditions, they are not merely breaking rules. They’re creating an entirely new identity for themselves, and that *is* the story.

The Key Question

What cultural assumption does your character accept without question at the start of the story? And what will loving this person force them to confront about their own world?

Map your character's invisible cage:

The invisible cage only becomes visible when your character wants something on the other side of the bars.

This is the moment when culture stops being background and becomes the central obstacle of your romance.

	PROTAGONIST	LOVE INTEREST
What cultural rule do they accept without question at the start?		
What moment or person makes the cage visible?		
What do they lose by seeing it? (Certainty, community, identity?)		
What do they gain?		

How to Think About Culture in Romantasy

Culture in romantasy is a constraint system. It's the social rules that determine what your characters can and can't do, what it costs them to step out of line, and what hoops they have to jump through to be together.

The tighter the constraints, the higher the tension. A culture where unmarried people can't be alone together makes every stolen moment electric. Loose constraints work too, but then your tension needs to come from somewhere else.

Don't explain culture through exposition. Let readers discover the rules when characters follow them, break them, or face consequences for crossing them. A single scene of social awkwardness teaches more than a paragraph of worldbuilding ever could.

Culture as Obstacle

The rules your characters must navigate or break:

- Taboos against certain relationships (class, species, enemy nations)
- Required courtship progressions that can't be skipped
- Chaperoning requirements that prevent privacy
- Reputation systems where being seen together causes damage
- Family involvement that creates external opposition

Culture as Opportunity

The customs that create romantic moments:

- Festivals where normal rules relax
- Dances that allow sanctioned touch
- Gift-giving traditions that let characters express interest
- Ceremonies that force proximity
- Traditions that create meaningful gestures

Culture as Revelation

How characters interact with cultural expectations shows who they are:

- Do they follow rules out of belief or fear?
- Do they break rules impulsively or deliberately?
- Do they chafe against expectations or never question them?

Some of the most interesting romantic tension comes from pairing characters who relate to their culture differently. One who embodies its values, one who challenges them.

Common Patterns: Culture in Romantasy

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The forbidden touch	Culture restricts physical contact; every brush of hands becomes charged	Slow-burn tension; meaningful small gestures
The reputation gamble	Being seen together risks social ruin	Stakes for every private moment; secrets
The courtship ladder	Expected progression that can't be skipped	Frustration when feelings outpace propriety
The chaperoned dance	Must interact under watchful eyes	Stolen glances; coded communication
The festival exception	One night when rules relax	Pivotal scenes; masks and anonymity
The cultural mistranslation	Gesture means different things in different cultures	Misunderstanding; revelation when explained

Which cultural patterns does your world use?

Pick 2-3 patterns from the reference table above that fit your romance. For each, note how it shows up in your story.

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR WORLD
<i>e.g., The forbidden touch — Fae cannot touch humans without burning them, so every accidental contact carries the weight of physical danger and forbidden desire</i>	

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. Skip what doesn't fit.

If your world mirrors a real culture, focus on what's different. You don't need to invent every custom from scratch. Zero in on what deviates from what readers will assume, and on the elements that create friction for your romance.

Common Mistakes with Cultural Worldbuilding

Mistake #1: The Inconsistent Culture

Cultural rules apply when convenient and disappear when inconvenient. Characters are chaperoned in one scene and alone together the next with no explanation. Stakes that come and go feel fake. If readers can't trust that the rules are real, they won't feel tension about breaking them.

FIX

Establish your rules clearly and enforce them consistently. If characters break rules, show consequences. If rules relax in certain circumstances, establish that pattern early.

Mistake #2: The Paper-Thin Taboo

Something is supposedly forbidden, but no one seems to actually care. The "forbidden" lovers face disapproval but no real consequences. Forbidden love only matters if the forbidding is real. Stakes need teeth.

FIX

Make consequences concrete and serious. Show other characters who suffered these consequences so readers know the threat is genuine.

Mistake #3: The Monolithic Culture

Everyone in a society thinks the same way, follows the same rules. No internal variation, no rebels, no regional differences.

FIX

Show variation. Some people enforce rules strictly; others look the other way. Older and younger generations may differ. Your characters should be able to find allies and enemies within their own culture.

Cultural Worldbuilding Self-Check

Review the culture you've built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Inconsistent Culture: Rules apply when convenient and disappear when inconvenient		
Paper-Thin Taboo: Something is supposedly forbidden, but no one seems to actually care and there are no real consequences		
Monolithic Culture: Everyone in the society thinks the same way with no internal variation, rebels, or regional differences		

Core Values & Worldview

Every single culture teaches its own set of fundamental beliefs: the virtues people learn in childhood, the attributes that make a person worthy of respect, the shortcomings that lead to shame. Your characters develop as a result of being shaped by those belief systems, even when they resist.

Because your characters are from different cultures, they have been raised on different values. So when their values collide (which will eventually happen), there is natural, authentic conflict. Allow your characters to grapple with fundamentally different views of life. The romance will grow stronger when they have to make genuine changes, not merely acceptance.

The Key Question

Which cultural values must your characters compromise or sacrifice to be together?

Reference: Cultural Values & Traits

Use this list when deciding what your culture values most. Pick 3-5 that define your world.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE VALUES
Personal Virtues	Honour, loyalty, courage, humility, patience, wisdom, honesty, compassion, self-reliance, cunning
Social Bonds	Family duty, clan loyalty, hospitality, community harmony, respect for elders, friendship, romantic love
Achievement	Ambition, excellence, competition, innovation, artistic mastery, scholarly pursuit, martial prowess
Spiritual	Piety, ritual observance, connection to ancestors, mystical insight, fate acceptance, divine service
Material	Wealth, status, land ownership, beautiful possessions, comfort, security, legacy
Freedom	Independence, personal choice, adventure, wanderlust, self-expression, breaking tradition

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE VALUES
Order	Tradition, hierarchy, obedience, propriety, law, duty, sacrifice for the greater good
Power	Strength, dominance, conquest, political influence, magical ability, control, leadership

What does your culture value most highly?

List 3-5 core values in order of importance:

How do these values create tension for your characters?

Values create tension when two characters' cultures prize different things, or when the same culture's values conflict with what love demands. A culture that values duty above all makes choosing love feel like choosing selfishness.

YOUR ANSWER

What does your culture consider shameful or dishonorable?

The flip side of values — what brings disgrace:

YOUR ANSWER

How does one character embody the cultural ideal while the other challenges it?

CHARACTER	RELATIONSHIP TO CULTURAL VALUES
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

What cultural value must one or both characters sacrifice to be together?

What virtue do they have to abandon, or what shame must they accept?

YOUR ANSWER

Gender Roles & Expectations

Gender (or equivalent social categories in your world) shapes behaviour, opportunities, and relationship dynamics. In many cases, societal expectations regarding gender dictate who will pursue and who will be pursued, who has agency to act versus waiting to act. This is fundamental because it affects everything that follows: daily life, family, courtship, hierarchy, and what your characters are even allowed to want.

Showing constraint of gender through big dramatic confrontations doesn't necessarily convey well the ways in which gender constrains individuals. It's through many small, almost imperceptible friction points that you can best illustrate this. The dress she wears limits her range of motion. The conversation she is prevented from participating in. The assumption made by others regarding her desires without ever asking if those assumptions were correct. For example, a character who has issues with the constraints of gender may express rebellion through small acts: unbuttoned corsets, secret reading material, or stolen time for personal practice. Her actions and behaviours may also be altered depending upon who is observing her, or she may maintain an internal dialogue questioning the rules she publicly abides by.

Don't overlook the costs associated with conformity, either. There may be mental fatigue, emotional exhaustion due to self-censorship, and personal sorrow for choices not made. When two people that have been socially constructed in differing manners fall in love with one another, allow them to perceive one another differently than others do. The space between how society views them and how their lover views them is precisely where the romance is located.

What are the general expectations for different genders in your culture?

Focus on what affects your story:

ASPECT	EXPECTATIONS
Expected roles and behaviors	
Prohibited roles and behaviors	

How do these expectations affect your characters?

CHARACTER	HOW GENDER EXPECTATIONS AFFECT THEM
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Does either character violate gender expectations?

How? What consequences do they face — social, legal, or personal?

YOUR ANSWER

How do gender expectations shape courtship?

Who pursues? Who waits? Who controls the pace?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when the “wrong” person takes the lead in courtship?

When someone breaks the expected courtship dynamic — the woman proposing, the lower-status person initiating — the social reaction reveals how rigid or flexible your culture truly is, and how much your characters risk by defying expectations.

YOUR ANSWER

Daily Life & Routines

To understand how culture shapes romantic experiences, you have to begin with how people live their lives. Romance occurs in the context of daily routines. Examining the patterns of living reveals when a couple will encounter each other and what is considered “normal.”

The number of routines you choose to depict isn’t as important as establishing a baseline for readers’ perception of what is normal and how much of an impact a deviation from that norm has. A couple of lines about a character’s morning rituals (they always take their tea; they always say their prayers) illustrate what a distraction or change means. Routine is a good method for developing character as well: what does the character do first? When in a rush, what does the character skip? What is the small comfort the character would never give up no matter what?

As soon as romance enters into a character’s routine, the reader will be able to sense the difference due to the prior knowledge of what was considered “normal.” Their character begins to wake up thinking of someone. The regular walk back home has new feelings because there could be this person. These little changes resonate with the reader because the reader understands the context from before.

What’s the rhythm of a typical day?

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
Morning (when do people wake? what happens first?)	
Midday (is there a rest period? a main meal?)	
Afternoon/Evening (when does work end? what follows?)	
Night (when do people sleep? what's nightlife like?)	

How does this rhythm differ by class or profession?

HOW DOES THIS RHYTHM DIFFER BY CLASS OR PROFESSION?

What's the weekly or monthly rhythm?

Market days? Rest days? Religious observances? Regular social gatherings?

YOUR ANSWER

What do people do when they're not working?

Leisure, entertainment, socializing — what fills non-work hours?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the love interest disrupt your protagonist’s routine?

Romance changes the texture of daily life. What shifts when your protagonist starts thinking about this person?

ROUTINE ELEMENT	BEFORE THE LOVE INTEREST	AFTER
<i>e.g., Morning tea ritual — Feyre used to eat alone at dawn, mechanically</i>	<i>Alone, silent, functional — tea was fuel, not comfort</i>	<i>She begins noticing whether Rhysand is already awake, listening for his movements, lingering over her cup</i>

Home & Household

Your home is the most intimate space in your world. It’s the place where characters are most themselves. The way homes are constructed, how many people share them, and the amount of privacy they provide will determine when and where your characters can be vulnerable with each other. Homes shared with servants or other people create vastly different possibilities for romance than homes lived in alone.

How your point-of-view character reacts (or doesn't react) to what they see upon entering a home is an indicator of their past experience. A character raised in poverty will count every single thing of value; a character from wealth will likely never recognise anything about their surroundings as luxurious, but rather notice immediately if something feels wrong. Instead of saying "the home was rich" use specific objects like "silver candlesticks left casually on a side table, more books than she'd seen in her life, a fire burning in an empty room."

As your character first enters their love interest's home, take some time to allow them to understand who this person is based upon where they live. That is a type of intimacy in itself.

What does a typical home look like for different classes?

CLASS	HOME DESCRIPTION
Wealthy/noble	
Middle/merchant	
Common/poor	

Who lives together?

Nuclear families? Extended families? Multiple generations? Servants in the household? Unmarried adults with parents?

YOUR ANSWER

How much privacy exists within a home?

Private bedrooms? Shared sleeping spaces? Thin walls? Servants everywhere?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a house a “home”?

What objects, rituals, or elements make a space feel like home in your culture?

YOUR ANSWER

What does your protagonist notice when they first enter the love interest’s home?

A home reveals who someone truly is. What details catch your protagonist’s eye — and what do those details tell them?

YOUR ANSWER

Family Structure & Relationships

Your characters' family is where their identity is formed prior to the story beginning; and also what they will be answering to once the story has begun. Expectations from their parents, siblings and other relatives will have commitments that conflict with those of romantic interests. In romantasy, family often acts as the first and most personal obstacle to finding true love.

A character caught between their feelings for another person and their obligation to their family is making a decision that your readers will relate to on a visceral level. You can show family dynamics through the little things: who speaks first at dinner, who always gives in to whom, whose opinion really matters even if there isn't an established order of authority. Approval from family members (and the lack of it) can speed up or kill a romance, and when a love interest gains the acceptance of a difficult parent, the reader also views this as a victory.

What's the typical family structure?

Who heads the household? How are decisions made? What's the hierarchy within a family?

YOUR ANSWER

What obligations exist between family members?

What do children owe parents? What do parents owe children? What about siblings, extended family?

YOUR ANSWER

How are children raised?

Who raises them (parents, extended family, nurses, community)? What are they taught? When do they start working or training?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens to orphans, unmarried adults, elderly without children?

How does the culture handle people outside the typical family structure?

YOUR ANSWER

How does family affect your characters’ romance?

Family is often the first and most personal obstacle to love. Whose approval matters? Who will try to interfere? What power does a parent or elder hold over the match?

CHARACTER	FAMILY'S STANCE ON THE RELATIONSHIP	WHAT POWER THEY HAVE TO INTERFERE
Protagonist’s family		
Love Interest’s family		

Food & Meals

Food shows culture. The foods we eat, the ways we prepare them, and with whom we eat them can tell you a great deal about values, resources, and social bonds.

Don’t have to invent a whole cuisine. Just focus on those aspects of food which will be relevant to your story: what would your characters share over a meal? What meal will they make for someone they love?

Eating together is one of the most simple ways to develop intimacy. When characters first begin to eat together, pay close attention to what they notice about each other's habits. Is she picking at her food? Is he eating as if he has no idea when his next meal will come? Cooking for someone is an act of caring. Use this in your writing. Refusing to eat with someone, or eating by yourself when you can be sharing a meal, also means something. To create a food scene that works well, you should slow down on the detail of the senses: the smell of the food, the warmth of a shared cup, the way a character tears apart their bread. Let the physical action of eating together do all the emotional work.

What's a typical meal like?

Meals are where your characters will share space, reveal habits, and build domestic intimacy. Knowing what people eat and how they eat it gives you the raw material for food scenes that do emotional heavy lifting.

MEAL	WHAT'S EATEN	HOW IT'S EATEN
Morning		
Midday		
Evening		

What's "special occasion" food vs. everyday food?

WHAT'S "SPECIAL OCCASION" FOOD VS. EVERYDAY FOOD?

What food rules or restrictions exist?

Religious restrictions? Class-based foods? Regional specialties? Seasonal availability?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the culture around drinking (alcohol or otherwise)?

When is drinking appropriate? What's drunk? What are drinking customs?

YOUR ANSWER



What are the rules around shared meals?

Who can eat together? Who eats first? Who serves? Are there forbidden combinations (class, gender, species)?

YOUR ANSWER

What does sharing a meal signify?

Friendship? Alliance? Courtship? Family acceptance? Sealing a deal?

YOUR ANSWER

What foods or drinks have romantic or special meaning?

Aphrodisiacs, festival foods, courting treats, magical foods:

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a meal where something important happens between your characters?

Food scenes do emotional heavy lifting — the shared cup, the meal cooked with care, the silence over a table.

What's the setting? What's eaten? What happens?

YOUR ANSWER

Architecture & Building

The way that people construct buildings can tell us a lot about who they are. A desert palace won't look anything like a northern fortress. No degree in architecture is required to recognise this.

All you really need to do is think about what would make sense with regards to each environment. In hot climates it is essential to create shade and allow for airflow. In cold climates, it is necessary to create thick walls that can keep the cold out, as well as large fireplaces that provide warmth. These differences in climate will give your readers a sense of place when travelling from one region to another. (For more on how climate shapes building, see Section 1: Geography & Environment.)

The way you construct your scenes can also impact the development of those scenes in practical ways. Narrow corridors force characters to stand close together. Great halls allow for a wide separation of characters across large tables. And the person that knows where all of the hidden passages are has the upper hand over the person that does not. When you are thinking about romantic scenes, consider how the layout of the room impacts the distance between characters, the amount of privacy they have, and the power dynamic of the scene.

What architectural style dominates your main setting?

Research real-world architecture that inspires your world. Note distinctive elements like columns, arches, domes, and materials.

YOUR ANSWER

What do different types of buildings look like?

How can your protagonist tell a temple from a tavern at a glance?

BUILDING TYPE	DISTINCTIVE FEATURES
Palace/noble estate	
Temple/place of worship	
Merchant's home/shop	
Common dwelling	
Military/fortification	

How does a specific building’s layout shape a romantic scene?

Narrow corridors force proximity. Great halls create distance. Hidden passages give one character power over another. Pick a key setting and map how its layout affects the dynamic between your characters.

SETTING	LAYOUT DETAIL	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANTIC DYNAMIC
<i>e.g., Spring Court manor — long corridors with alcoves hidden behind tapestries</i>	<i>e.g., Characters can slip out of sight for a moment but footsteps echo, so they can always hear someone approaching</i>	

Religion & Spirituality in Daily Life

If religion has been a key aspect of your story, consider expanding upon it in Section 6: Religion, Myth & Prophecy. Focus on how religion is part of the everyday lives of your characters.

A person's religion in everyday life is based on habits, not theology. The small rituals people go through without thinking, the phrases that are spoken without thought, and the gestures that mark the different stages of each day. They provide for your world the "lived-in" quality, and help create a common (or conflicting) spiritual vocabulary among your characters.

Most religions are rooted in the small things: how someone prays before a meal, what someone says when receiving bad news, and a shrine that exists in almost every home. Inevitably, when two characters' religions clash, there will be conflict; and when two characters quietly pray together, there is intimacy. A character finding out that their love interest knows their prayer, or mouthing along with a blessing they don't believe in simply because they want to show respect, is an intimate gesture that provides significant romantic impact.

What role does religion/spirituality play in daily life?

These details will determine whether your characters share a spiritual vocabulary or must navigate different faiths — both of which shape the intimacy available to them.

Daily prayers or rituals? Religious dietary restrictions? Spiritual interpretations of everyday events?

YOUR ANSWER

What life events have religious significance?

Birth, coming of age, marriage, death — what rituals mark these transitions?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people interact with religious institutions or figures?

Priests, temples, shrines — how present are they in ordinary life?

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered sacred or profane?

What places, objects, words, or actions carry spiritual weight?

YOUR ANSWER

How does religion create tension or intimacy between your characters?

Do they pray to different gods? Does one character's faith demand something the other can't give? Is there a moment when one character quietly participates in the other's spiritual practice out of respect?

YOUR ANSWER

Superstitions & Folk Beliefs

Beyond formal religion, most cultures have their own folk beliefs. These are things everyone knows even though they can't tell you how they know. This little stuff makes a world that feels lived in.

These small superstitions will also show you how a person thinks by showing their character through what they do, not just by telling you. A hard-boiled soldier who still won't walk underneath a ladder tells you something that could never be told with words. Folk beliefs can generate small moments of connection or conflict for your characters too. Is one of your characters charmed by the other's superstition, or do they think they're foolish? If a superstition comes true, it could knock the ground right from underneath your characters' feet. And there's something sweet about a character that doesn't believe in good luck still carrying a charm because the person they love gave it to them.

Reference: Common Superstitions & Omens

Use this list for inspiration. Pick a few that fit your world's mood and culture.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Lucky/Unlucky Numbers	Three for luck, seven for magic, thirteen cursed, odd numbers for the living, even for the dead
Animal Omens	Ravens mean death, white animals are blessed, black cats bring luck (or doom), owls warn of secrets
Weather Signs	Red sky warnings, thunder during weddings, rain on a journey's start, fog hiding spirits
Protective Actions	Iron wards off fae, salt purifies, crossing thresholds with right foot, spitting to avert evil eye
Bad Luck Triggers	Speaking a dead person's name, whistling at night, opening umbrellas indoors, breaking mirrors
Good Luck Rituals	Knocking wood, throwing coins in water, carrying charms, first-footing at new year, bride's "something old"

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Threshold Beliefs	Don't step on cracks, carry brides over doorways, leave offerings at crossroads, dawn/dusk are dangerous
Dreams & Visions	Dreams of water mean change, falling dreams warn of pride, dreaming of someone means they're thinking of you

What common superstitions exist?

Lucky/unlucky numbers, colors, animals? Actions that invite bad fortune? Protective gestures or phrases?

YOUR ANSWER

What everyday rituals do people perform without thinking?

Knocking on wood, crossing fingers, small offerings, phrases spoken at certain moments:

YOUR ANSWER

What do people believe about dreams, omens, or signs?

WHAT DO PEOPLE BELIEVE ABOUT DREAMS, OMENS, OR SIGNS?

What folk remedies or beliefs exist around health, love, or fortune?

WHAT FOLK REMEDIES OR BELIEFS EXIST AROUND HEALTH, LOVE, OR FORTUNE?

Does a superstition or folk belief play a role in your characters' relationship?

A charm given as a gift, a shared ritual that becomes “their thing,” a superstition one character finds endearing in the other — small beliefs can create intimacy.

YOUR ANSWER

Manners, Etiquette & Everyday Politeness

Etiquette is an unwritten set of rules that we follow in our daily lives; which person says hello first, when does one stop speaking to allow another to go first. In romantasy, the “rules” of etiquette are a battleground for characters. Each time someone breaks some social rule you see something about where they come from, each deliberate violation is a statement of power and control, and the tension between what politeness requires and what desire demands drives countless charged scenes.

Do not tell your readers the rules of etiquette. Rather, show your readers the transgression and the subsequent reactions of those around them. Write down the immediate physiological response from others after the character makes a social faux pas: the gasp, the look shared among the people present, the pause in the conversation before the dialogue resumes. Allow your character to feel the wrongness of their actions before they have any idea why. And when depicting intentional violations of etiquette rules, show the internal calculation. Your character knows what they are risking and chooses to act anyway.

Etiquette becomes romantic tension as a result of one character watching another learn the “rules” of the world around them. The competence or ineptitude, the minute corrections that guide the newcomer, and the moment the outsider figures out the correct way to behave. A small social infraction is usually much more effective than a large offence: the cutting remark, the incorrect form of address, the turned shoulder.

How do people greet each other?

RELATIONSHIP	GREETING
Strangers	
Acquaintances	
Friends	
Family	
Superior to inferior (class/age/rank)	
Inferior to superior	

What's considered rude in everyday interaction?

Behaviors that give offense, things that aren't done:

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered polite or hospitable?

Offering food/drink to guests? Specific gestures of respect? Customs around visiting someone's home?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people handle conflict or disagreement?

Direct confrontation? Indirect communication? Mediation through third parties?

YOUR ANSWER

What social mistake does one character make that the other notices?

Etiquette violations reveal where someone comes from and create charged moments between characters. What faux pas creates a scene between your protagonists?

THE MISTAKE	WHO MAKES IT	HOW THE OTHER REACTS

Hospitality & Guest Rights

While it may seem like hospitality would be a minor detail when building a world, in romantasy it can be one of the most dependable ways to generate romantic tension. Both of your characters are continually entering into each other's space, and the obligations that come from being a guest or a host establish a precarious, intimate dynamic that has a lot of opportunity.

Hospitality is ultimately a social contract. A host provides the guest with three things: safety, food and shelter, and passage from place to place. Guests have a few responsibilities: be polite, follow the host's house rules, and restrain their desires. Many fantasy worlds consider this contract sacred; a violation of it is more egregious than normal betrayal because it tears at the very fabric that holds together the community of strangers in hostile territory. In Fae-inspired settings, hospitality can literally become a binding contract. Each meal you eat, each gift you accept, and each word of gratitude you say can bind you to a host's obligation without even realising it.

One of the reasons that hospitality is such a great way to build tension between two people is the vulnerability that exists on both sides. As a guest, you're dependent on someone else's resources and therefore vulnerable and visible; there are rules you'll have to follow that you may not fully understand. The host is responsible for providing for another person, exposing themselves through their home and performing a version of themselves to an audience of one. By having your protagonist enter their love interest's home as a guest, the dynamic of vulnerability is already established by the time anyone starts speaking.

Hospitality in *A Court of Thorns and Roses* begins as a form of imprisonment for Feyre. She arrives at the Spring Court as a debtor, not a voluntary guest. Although Tamlin presents her stay as hospitality (fine clothes, beautiful rooms, all of her needs met), the true nature of her stay is as a captive. His hospitality becomes increasingly restrictive as time passes, culminating in him locking Feyre in the manor with an air shield for her "protection." While providing for her physical needs, Tamlin ignores her mental and emotional needs. After Feyre moves to the Night Court, Rhysand clearly states to her that she is his guest and not his prisoner. He reinforces this by teaching her how to defend herself, even within his own home. The two Courts were worlds apart: the difference between hospitality as a tool of control and hospitality as actual refuge.

Jude Duarte in *The Cruel Prince* is a perpetual guest living under conditions of precarious hospitality. After having been taken in by Madoc (a Fae General responsible for murdering her biological parents), she is educated and provided with the same luxuries as the Fae gentry, yet constantly reminded of her mortality and lower standing. Madoc provides for the children as a result of a sense of honour and obligation, as he views them as his wife's offspring. But this type of hospitality is both conditional and limiting. Perhaps the greatest betrayal of guest rights occurs when Valerian forces Jude to consume the Everapple, a fruit that renders people susceptible and compliant. This is a clear break in the trust of the dining table, where feeding a guest is meant to be a sign of security. Jude's journey is largely defined by her transformation from a vulnerable guest into the person behind the throne, utilising the knowledge that her host provided for her to gain the upper hand against him.

What does a guest owe their host?

Respect for house rules? Gifts? Restraint? What behaviour would violate guest rights? Are there things a guest must never do (ask certain questions, enter certain rooms, refuse offered food)?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when hospitality is violated?

By either party. What are the consequences of betraying a guest or dishonouring a host? Is the penalty social, legal, magical, or divine?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your protagonist’s guest status affect the romance?

Are they a willing guest, a reluctant one, or a prisoner in all but name? How does the power imbalance of guest and host shape the early dynamic between your characters?

YOUR ANSWER

Which hospitality pattern does your romance use?

These three patterns shape some of the most effective romantic dynamics in the genre. The gilded cage traps through luxury, the host’s exposure creates accidental vulnerability, and the violation cuts deepest because it breaks a sacred trust.

PATTERN	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW IT SHOWS UP IN YOUR STORY
The gilded cage (luxury without autonomy)		
The host’s exposure (home reveals truth)		
The violation (broken contract, deeper betrayal)		

What threshold rituals exist in your world?

The more elaborate the welcoming ritual, the greater the weight when it’s violated. What must happen when a guest arrives — and what does it mean when someone skips a step?

YOUR ANSWER

Entertainment, Arts & Leisure

What your character does in their leisure time will show you what they value. The way characters interact with each other during leisure time also provides a natural setting for them to meet outside of their normal roles. The stories that are told, the games that are played, and the ways cultures express themselves through the arts all reveal deeper values about what really matters.

Leisure time is great for creating opportunities for your characters to spend time together while being outside of their normal relationship dynamic. A dance requires physical contact. A game shows how competitive someone is. A shared story creates inside jokes and common ground. In many cases, leisure activities provide a “cover” for characters to spend time together without acknowledging the real reason why they want to. And honestly, when a character continues to attend the same tavern game night over and over again, or has an unexplained sudden interest in an art form their love interest practises, it’s very obvious to everyone else. The transparent nature of this behaviour adds to its charm.

What entertainment is common?

Leisure activities give your characters excuses to spend time together outside their normal roles. A dance requires touch. A game reveals personality. A shared story creates inside jokes. What does your world offer? Music, theater, games, sports, storytelling, gambling — what do people do for enjoyment?

YOUR ANSWER

What stories or legends does everyone know?

The cultural touchstones — tales children grow up hearing, references everyone understands:

YOUR ANSWER

What music exists? When is it played?

Instruments, styles, occasions for music:

YOUR ANSWER

What games or sports do people play?

WHAT GAMES OR SPORTS DO PEOPLE PLAY?

What art forms are valued?

Visual arts, crafts, performance, literature — what does this culture create and prize?

YOUR ANSWER

What leisure activity brings your characters together?

Dances require touch. Games reveal personality. Shared stories create inside jokes. What activity gives your characters an excuse to spend time together — and does everyone else see through the excuse?

ACTIVITY	WHAT IT ALLOWS (TOUCH, CONVERSATION, COMPETITION, PROXIMITY)	HOW OBVIOUS IS IT THAT THEY'RE THERE FOR EACH OTHER?
<i>e.g., Weekly tavern card game — Xaden starts showing up to a game he never attended before Violet joined</i>	<i>e.g., Seated across from each other, sustained eye contact, banter disguised as competitive trash-talk</i>	<i>e.g., Everyone at the table knows exactly why he's there except Violet</i>

Oaths, Promises & Honour

In many romantasy worlds, people's words carry value. Culturally, socially, and at times magically. Oaths of allegiance, sworn promises, and honour debts often create commitments which have the potential to create direct conflicts with the heart's desires. This theme of a person's word as a contract is especially prevalent in Fae-inspired settings; spoken words are literal contracts. When a bargain is made correctly, under the right circumstances, it creates a binding obligation, and the definition of "equal" repayment can lie completely with the other party.

The romantic tension in oath culture comes from collision. As soon as a character's sworn duty and their growing love are mutually exclusive, the tension begins. A character who swore to protect the realm now loves someone the realm considers a threat. A character who promised their dying parent they'd marry for alliance now wants to marry for love. A guard assigned to protect someone's purity finds himself dismantling the very rules he swore to uphold.

Oaths have an inherent value in romantic tension because they were normally given when the character had no idea what they would be losing. The oath seemed like no big deal at the time, since the oath did not conflict with anything the character wanted. It wasn't until the character develops romantic feelings for someone that the cost of the oath becomes apparent, and the commitment has already been made.

Oaths That Live in the Body

Romantasy worlds with the strongest oaths don't treat them as social norms; they give them physical consequences. What happens when you make a deal? It manifests as a tattoo that cannot be erased. When you break a promise, it causes you pain, sickness, or death. When your commitment lives in your body, ignoring it is impossible, and the tension between responsibility and passion becomes unendurable.

Romantasy oath culture has little resemblance to historical fiction. Where failure to honour your word can kill you, every single promise you make is a potential trap. Because the wording of the oath can be so important, characters in these worlds often treat every single word very carefully, not necessarily because they are clever, but because their life may depend on it. The distinction between "I will serve you" and "I will serve your interests" could be the difference between slavery and strategic alliance.

Rhysand and Feyre's bargain in *A Court of Thorns and Roses* is probably the most compelling use of oath-as-romantic-engine in the genre. Feyre bargained herself away to Rhysand for one week each month to stay alive while she was held captive Under the Mountain. This binding agreement is tattooed onto her body and remains even after she is transformed into a Fae, indicating that the promise is tied to the soul and not the body. When Feyre does not fulfil her part of the bargain for three months, she begins to experience the effects physically:

nightmares, losing weight, becoming sick repeatedly, all of which disappear once she arrives at the Night Court. What's also incredibly rewarding about oath-based relationships in romance is the loophole. That moment when a character finds a way to honour the letter of their promise while violating its spirit (or vice versa). The and she is physically drawn to him, which complicates every question of agency and choice. The tension is a loophole provides a visual example of how the character is both constrained by the rules and smart enough to that the bargain exists independently of feelings. He did not ask for her love, he asked for her presence during

What does breaking one's word cost in your culture?

Social disgrace? Exile? Loss of rank or magic? Physical pain? Somatic illness? Something worse?

YOUR ANSWER

Are oaths in your world purely cultural, or do they carry magical weight?

Can a bargain be literally binding? Does it manifest physically (a tattoo, a mark, a compulsion)? What happens if someone tries to break a magically enforced oath?

YOUR ANSWER

Does your world's oath system have loopholes?

Can precise wording be exploited? Is the letter or the spirit of the promise what matters? How might your characters use the system's rigidity to create space for personal choice?

YOUR ANSWER

What oath conflicts with your characters' romance?

Which promise must be broken, or creatively reinterpreted, for them to be together? Did the character know what they were giving up when they made the oath, or did love change the equation?

YOUR ANSWER

Write the oath.

If precise wording matters in your world, draft the actual words of the promise that binds your character. Then look for the loophole. What could those words mean that the speaker didn't intend?

	DETAILS
The exact words of the oath	
Who it was sworn to	
What it was intended to mean	
What it could literally mean (the loophole)	
What it costs to break outright	

Taboos & Forbidden Things

The forbidden shows what the culture fears. In romantasy, taboos are the “forbidden love” stakes, and they will only be as effective as how well defined and important they are for each character involved.

Forbidden love has its excitement in the risk involved. Ensure that your reader understands the consequences of breaking the taboo for each character before they do so. The first transgression must feel dangerous. Subsequent transgressions may increase the risk, or they may make the previously forbidden become acceptable. Both options can be used; however, having an idea of which you plan to use is helpful.

What actions, topics, or behaviors are taboo in your culture?

CATEGORY	TABOO BEHAVIORS
Physical (touch, proximity, eye contact, showing skin)	
Verbal (certain words, discussing feelings, speaking across gender/class)	
Social (cross-class interaction, public displays, being alone together)	
Magical (certain powers, displaying abilities, magical contact between people)	
Sexual (anything related to intimacy before or outside marriage)	

Which taboos directly affect your romance?

Pick 2-3 that create real obstacles:

TABOO	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANCE

What happens when someone breaks a taboo?

Consequences should escalate with severity:

SEVERITY	CONSEQUENCE
Minor taboo broken	
Moderate taboo broken	
Major taboo broken	

What taboo do your characters break first?

This is often a pivotal early scene — the first boundary crossed:

YOUR ANSWER

What taboo must they break to be together fully?

This might be the climactic choice — the line they can't uncross:

YOUR ANSWER

Sexuality, Desire & Intimacy Norms

Every society has its own way of regulating desire. The question is: what counts as appropriate sexual behaviour, who can pursue whom sexually, and what happens to individuals (notably women) if they violate these norms? The answers to these questions reside at the centre of romantic conflict in the genre. In addition to external barriers such as war and geography, the expectations surrounding purity are internalised to the point that they become part of the character's inner dialogue, defining both what she does and what she believes she may or may not want.

So purity culture becomes such a potent tool in romantasy. As opposed to a character who is battling an external enemy, a character who is battling the voice within her own head that tells her *wanting this makes me ruined* is a very different type of struggle. The genre is particularly effective in conveying this type of conflict.

A very common structure in romantasy is what you might call the **architecture of restriction**: the culture creates elaborate rules regarding the protagonist's sexuality (veils, chaperones, ritualistic practices, physical isolation) and the romance develops as the rules are slowly dismantled. Each stolen glance, each forbidden touch, and each secret conversation carry the weight of the possible consequences of discovery. The restrictions themselves do half the heavy lifting of building up the slow burn for you.

In *From Blood and Ash*, the Maiden Rules demonstrate the architecture of restriction perfectly. Poppy is not simply expected to be a virgin; her entire existence is designed to reinforce that expectation. She is required to wear a veil, and to never be physically touched by anyone. She's forbidden from having direct eye contact with individuals, being spoken to informally, or having any physical contact with others. The rules create a double barrier; they restrict her ability to engage in sexual activity and her ability to develop a desire to begin with. So when Hawke arrives as her guard, one of the few people permitted to see her face, the simplest types of intimate contact (a glance, a casual conversation, a brush on the back) take on an enormous level of transgression. Poppy's rebellion begins not with a grand escape, but rather with a clandestine visit to a tavern where she wears a mask, thus trading one form of concealment for another, simply so that she may experience a kiss. The architecture of restriction makes even the smallest gestures of desire seem monumental.

But restrictions aren't sufficient alone. It is the **double standard** that allows these romance obstacles to operate; the difference between what is expected of women and what is allowed for men. In most romantasy worlds (and I am being truthful when I say it is the same way in many actual worlds) the male love interest arrives with hundreds of years of experience, a rakish reputation, and nothing will happen to him, while the female protagonist's worth is determined based upon how little she knows. This double standard creates tension in both directions. The female protagonist must deal with the internalised shame regarding the fact that she wants, while the experienced male love interest must prove himself worthy of the trust of someone who has been told that wanting is bad.

Perhaps the most exciting aspect of purity norms is showing the moment your protagonist recognises them. *Bridgerton* makes this double standard obvious. Anthony Bridgerton openly keeps a mistress, while at the same time chasing away any suitors he deems unworthy of Daphne, whose entire value in the marriage restriction as oppressive until they meet someone who views desire as normal, and not as something to be market depends on her perceived virtue. If Daphne is even thought to have made a mistake or been alone

How are these norms enforced?

Social shame? Physical punishment? Religious consequence? Loss of status or marriageability? Who does the enforcing: family, religious authorities, the community at large?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens to someone who violates these norms?

Particularly for women. What are the consequences of being perceived as sexually transgressive? Are they the same for men?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your protagonist’s relationship with desire affect their romance?

Do they feel shame? Freedom? Confusion? Curiosity they’ve been taught to suppress? How does their love interest challenge or affirm their sense of self?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does the double standard live in your world?

What’s permitted for one gender that would destroy the other? How does this asymmetry create tension between your characters?

BEHAVIOUR	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE PROTAGONIST	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE LOVE INTEREST
Being seen alone with someone		
Sexual experience/history		
Expressing desire openly		

Map the architecture of restriction — and the sequence of dismantling

If your protagonist lives under layers of rules designed to control their sexuality or intimacy, the romance develops as those layers are removed one by one. Map the restrictions from mildest to most extreme, then note which one falls first — and which one is the last to go.

LAYER OF RESTRICTION	WHAT RULE OR CUSTOM ENFORCES IT	WHEN DOES IT FALL IN THE STORY?
<i>The veil — Poppy cannot be seen by anyone outside the temple</i>	<i>Maiden Law, enforced by the priestesses and her guards</i>	<i>Falls first — Hawke sees her face when assigned as her guard</i>
<i>No informal speech — the Maiden cannot be addressed casually</i>	<i>Social custom, reinforced by everyone around her</i>	<i>Falls second — Hawke speaks to her like a person, not a title</i>
<i>No physical contact — she cannot be touched by anyone</i>	<i>Maiden Law, with physical separation enforced by her quarters and guards</i>	<i>Falls late — each touch escalates the stakes</i>

Reputation, Gossip & Public Opinion

In many cultures, how others perceive you can be just as important as your actions. Rumours spread quickly and reputation is often delicate. What once was, in some cases, could be irreversibly lost forever.

The way people react to your character when they enter a space can represent their feelings toward them. Does the room fall silent? Do people move closer or edge away? The quiet, unspoken comments your character cannot quite catch will heighten the reader’s tension. Represent the pressure of the public’s perception with the subtleties: the small, almost unnoticed slights, the intentional glances, and the closing of the door.

How does information travel in your society?

HOW DOES INFORMATION TRAVEL IN YOUR SOCIETY?

What destroys a reputation?

What’s the kind of scandal that follows someone forever? Is it the same for all classes and genders?

POSITION	WHAT DESTROYS THEIR REPUTATION
Someone of the protagonist’s position	
Someone of the love interest’s position	

Can a ruined reputation be recovered? How?

Some cultures allow redemption; others don't. Is there a path back, or is ruin permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

Who are the gossips and rumormongers in your story?

Who spreads information — maliciously or carelessly? Who might your characters need to avoid, bribe, or silence?

YOUR ANSWER

What rumors might circulate about your characters' relationship?

Even if nothing has happened yet, what might people *say* is happening?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the worst thing that could be said about either character?

The rumor that would destroy them — true or not:

CHARACTER	WORST POSSIBLE RUMOR
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

How do your characters protect their reputations while pursuing each other?

What precautions do they take? What lies do they tell? What image do they maintain?

YOUR ANSWER

Privacy, Surveillance & Being Watched

It is when we are denied our private moments that we begin to value them. But private moments are hard to come by; it is this lack of privacy that creates the feeling of earning intimacy.

Private time can vary dramatically from one culture to another. For some people, being alone in a room together is scandalous, while a busy marketplace provides far more anonymity than an empty hallway where servants have eyes and ears everywhere. It is because privacy is so rare that every stolen moment means something. A near-discovery builds beautiful tension: the footsteps in the hallway, the knock on the door, the voice in the next room. The fact that you are always aware that you could be discovered at any time makes every private glance dangerous.

The process of creating their own privacy together is itself a type of intimacy. They discover a secluded place. They fabricate reasons for being alone. They get to know each other's schedules. Together, they create a private world that only they share.

How much privacy exists in your world?

Consider: Do servants see everything? Do nobles have private chambers? Do commoners share living spaces? Is magical surveillance possible?

YOUR ANSWER

Where can your characters be alone together?

List the spaces where privacy is possible — and what risks each location carries:

LOCATION	RISK OF DISCOVERY

Where are they always watched?

Courts, public spaces, family homes, workplaces — where is privacy impossible?

YOUR ANSWER

Who might be watching or listening?

Servants, guards, family members, rivals, magical surveillance, spies:

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen if they were seen together?

CONTEXT	CONSEQUENCE
Seen talking privately	
Seen alone together	
Seen in physical contact	

What excuse or cover story do they use when almost caught?

WHAT EXCUSE OR COVER STORY DO THEY USE WHEN ALMOST CAUGHT?

Is there a moment in your story when they ARE seen?

Who sees them? What happens next?

YOUR ANSWER

Touch, Proximity & Physical Boundaries

In many societies, there are rules about who may physically touch whom, and to what extent. Touch restrictions have the power to create a slow burn feeling in romance. When a simple brush of the fingers with another person is seen as taboo, it carries a charge that explicit contact in a more permissive culture simply can't match.

Accidental touches are electrified in these societies. Write the moment your main character's hand brushes against another person's, and they both stop dead in their tracks. The warmth of being too close to each other in a crowded room. The more forbidden touch is, the more weight a single point of contact carries.

Bridgerton is a perfect example of this. In a Regency setting where unmarried people can barely be alone together, every gloved hand on an arm carries weight. When Anthony removes Kate's bee sting in The Viscount Who Loved Me, although it was strictly a medical procedure, the transgression of touching bare skin in that world made it one of the most charged scenes in the book. You do not have to include any form of explicit content, as placing a hand on a bare shoulder in some societies would be scandalous enough.

What touch is considered appropriate between unmarried people?

Map the boundaries:

CATEGORY	WHAT'S INCLUDED
Always acceptable	
Acceptable in certain contexts (chaperoned, public, formal)	
Borderline or scandalous	
Absolutely forbidden	

What physical distance is expected between unmarried people?

WHAT PHYSICAL DISTANCE IS EXPECTED BETWEEN UNMARRIED PEOPLE?

What touch is considered particularly intimate — perhaps more so than a kiss?

What's YOUR culture's unexpected intimacy?

YOUR ANSWER

When do your characters first break the touch barrier?

Describe the scene — what boundary do they cross? Was it intentional or accidental? How do they react?

YOUR ANSWER

What touch do they share in private that they couldn't share in public?

The contrast between public restraint and private contact creates tension:

YOUR ANSWER



Are unmarried people allowed to be alone together?

If no — who must be present? Under what circumstances can they be unchaperoned?

YOUR ANSWER

Who acts as chaperone for your characters?

Is this person sympathetic, oblivious, or hostile to the romance?

YOUR ANSWER

How do they evade supervision?

What excuses, distractions, or locations allow them to be alone?

YOUR ANSWER

If they ARE alone together, what does that imply?

Does it automatically suggest impropriety? Is their reputation ruined? Are they now obligated to marry?

YOUR ANSWER

Dress, Appearance & Adornment

Dressing tells us who we are: our social standing, how available we are, our values and beliefs. In addition, clothing creates its own romantic tension. The veil that cannot be removed, the colour that says “do not speak to me,” the hair that only your spouse can see unbound.

Dress in detail and observe what your characters pay attention to when it comes to each other’s clothes. What your protagonist focuses on with regards to another character’s appearance will give your readers an idea of where their eyes keep going back to: how fabric falls, a scar that is hidden under the edge of a collar, a ring that is or isn’t being worn.

Transitions in wardrobe also serve well as indicators of how intimate the relationship has become. Armour removed, hair unbound, formal wear discarded. Each layer of clothing that is removed is a layer of distance that has been removed.

What Clothing Signals

What does clothing communicate in your culture?

MARKER TYPE	WHAT CLOTHING COMMUNICATES
Class markers	
Profession markers	
Marital/availability markers	
Religious markers	

Are there sumptuary laws — rules about who can wear what?

Certain fabrics, colors, or styles restricted to certain classes? Penalties for dressing “above your station”?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean for your character to dress outside their station?

Disguise? Scandal? Crime? Social death?

YOUR ANSWER

Fashion by Class & Context

What do people actually wear? You don't need to describe every stitch, just know enough to make your descriptions feel true when they matter to the scene.

CONTEXT	WEALTHY/NOBLE	COMMON/WORKING
Daily wear		
Formal events		
Work/labour		
Religious occasions		
Mourning		
Wedding/celebration		

For historical fashion terminology (chemise, doublet, kirtle, stays, etc.), see Section 20: Quick Reference Sheets.

What are your world's distinctive garments?

What clothing exists in your world that doesn't exist in ours? Magical garments? Cultural specifics?

YOUR ANSWER

Covered & Revealed

What parts of the body are typically covered?

What's modest dress in your culture? Does it differ by gender, class, or context?

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered scandalous or provocative to reveal?

WHAT'S CONSIDERED SCANDALOUS OR PROVOCATIVE TO REVEAL?

What does revealing something usually hidden mean?

If someone shows skin they normally cover, what does that signal? Trust? Intimacy? Invitation? Shame?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there something one character shows the other that they don't show anyone else?

A physical vulnerability? A hidden mark? Simply their unguarded appearance?

YOUR ANSWER

Hair & Its Meanings

What do hairstyles signify in your culture?

Bound vs. loose? Cut vs. uncut? Covered vs. uncovered? Specific styles for specific statuses?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there significance to who can touch someone's hair?

Is it intimate? Forbidden? Reserved for family or spouse?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment when one character sees the other's hair differently than usual?

Unbound, wet, disheveled, cut — and what does it mean?

YOUR ANSWER

Tokens of Dress

Are there clothing items exchanged in courtship or marriage?

Rings, pins, sashes, cloaks, veils — items that mark someone as courting or claimed?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean to give or receive such an item?

Interest? Betrothal? Binding commitment?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean to remove or reject such an item?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO REMOVE OR REJECT SUCH AN ITEM?

Is there a garment or accessory that becomes significant between your characters?

Something given, borrowed, kept, or returned:

YOUR ANSWER

Undressing as Intimacy

What does it mean to see someone in states of undress?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO SEE SOMEONE IN STATES OF UNDRRESS?

When do your characters first see each other less than fully dressed?

What are the circumstances? What does each see?

YOUR ANSWER

What layers come off over the course of the relationship?

Each layer removed is a layer of distance dissolved. Map the progression — from the first small reveal to the moment when they’re fully unguarded around each other.

STAGE OF RELATIONSHIP	WHAT'S REMOVED OR REVEALED	WHAT IT SIGNIFIES
Early (formal, guarded)	She removes her gloves in his presence — the first time she’s shown bare hands	A crack in the armour; she’s stopped performing

Is there a garment that represents armor or protection that one character removes around the other?

Literal armor? A mask? Formal court dress? Religious garments? What does removing it signify?

YOUR ANSWER

Courtship Customs & Romantic Expectations

All cultures have a romantic script: the expected ways to indicate interest, as well as the approved sequence of events from stranger to spouse. If we don't understand what the normal expectations of these scripts are, then the deviations may be difficult to identify.

The romantic tension in courtship customs comes from the gap between what's expected and what's felt. There is a character performing the required actions but burning beneath the surface. A character who has no idea where they are in the process, and must be guided by the person they're interested in. And then there is the intimacy of learning how to perform the scripted actions. You want to portray characters who are acutely aware of which step in the process they are currently engaged in, constantly trying to determine if they can skip over the next step, frustrated with the rigid pacing that doesn't match their feelings. Once a couple deviates from the script, it should be apparent that both parties involved are conscious of what they are doing. "This is not the way things are typically done," one party may express, and the other responds, "I am aware." The script becomes most important once the couple deviates from it.

In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy has lived her entire life adhering to the rules of the Maiden. She is never allowed to be touched, seen, or spoken to informally. So every time Poppy and Hawke interact and break one of these rules, there is a sense of tension present precisely because both are aware of what the rules are, and are purposefully ignoring them. The courtship is not characterised by romantic gestures such as flowers or formally introducing themselves. Rather, it's comprised of secretly conversing with one another, forbidden touch, and slowly breaking down every rule that Poppy has been taught since birth. With each step they skip, there is a sense of danger present because the consequences are real.

How do people show romantic interest?

What's the cultural script for "I'm interested in you"?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the expected progression of a relationship?

Map the steps from “strangers” to “married”:

Who initiates courtship?

One gender? Either? Families? Does it vary by class?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the role of family in courtship?

Must families approve? Arrange meetings? Give formal consent? Or do individuals choose freely?

YOUR ANSWER

How long is a typical courtship?

Weeks? Months? Years? Is a long courtship expected, or can people marry quickly?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your characters violate courtship expectations?

Do they skip steps? Move too fast? Pursue when they shouldn't? Ignore family involvement?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean if someone violates the expected progression?

VIOLATION	WHAT IT SIGNALS
Moving too fast	
Skipping family involvement	
Pursuing someone “above” them	

What gestures are considered romantic in your culture?

Describe 3 gestures that signal love or interest:

What gestures would be considered too forward or inappropriate?

What romantic gesture does one character make that surprises the other?

Something that reveals more than they intended, or that the other didn't expect:

YOUR ANSWER

Tokens, Gifts & Symbols

Gifts in the context of courtship can be thought of as their own unique form of communication. The right gift at the right time signals interest; too much interest, however, can communicate presumptuousness or even ignorance of the recipient.

Each gift scene has three components: the act of giving, the act of receiving, and the after-effects. To maximise the impact of each of these elements, slow down through all three. The giver: what did they give? Why did they choose this gift? How nervous or confident were they when presenting? Did they offer explanation or allow the gift to stand for itself? The receiver: the moment of recognition (or confusion), physical contact with the gift, the decision on how to respond. The aftermath: where does the gift go? How many times is the gift physically touched or looked at? Is the gift put away, or placed out for view? While the actual gift itself is important, the emotional weight the giver places upon it carries much greater significance. But specific gifts chosen based on some preference or observation carry much greater weight than generic “beautiful jewellery.” A gift that reflects the giver’s awareness of the receiver (remembered a preference, noticed a need) will always land harder than an expensive gift that merely demonstrates wealth.

Are there traditional courtship gifts or tokens?

What objects carry romantic meaning? (Flowers, jewelry, handkerchiefs, enchanted items, etc.)

YOUR ANSWER

What does giving or accepting such a token signify?

Interest? Serious intent? Engagement? Binding commitment?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either of your characters give such a token — or refuse one?

What happens and what does it mean?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there an object that becomes meaningful to your couple specifically?

Not a traditional token, but something that gains significance between them:

YOUR ANSWER

Plan a gift scene using the three components.

The most powerful gift scenes slow down through all three stages: giving, receiving, and aftermath. A gift that shows the giver noticed something specific about the receiver always lands harder than one that merely demonstrates wealth.

COMPONENT	DETAILS
The gift (what is it? why this gift specifically?)	
The giving (how nervous/confident? explanation or silence?)	
The receiving (recognition, confusion, physical contact with the gift)	
The aftermath (where does the gift go? how often is it touched or looked at?)	

Marriage Customs & Ceremonies

Marriage is where individualised love becomes a public rite of passage. Who can marry whom? What rituals must be performed? What makes a union legitimate? These customs define the endgame of your romance and the obstacles standing in its way.

These customs will determine whether your characters are rushing towards marriage or trying to escape it. Weddings create great set-piece moments. Since they are public, the ceremony can increase tension: the vows have to be said out loud, the witnesses can watch for hesitation, the moment when an objection can be raised. No matter whether the couple is getting married with open arms or against their will, the ceremony should have a sense of finality. Take your time to describe what your character sees, hears, and feels during the ceremony, and let the ritual carry the emotional weight.

What makes a marriage “real” in cultural terms – beyond legal requirements?

Religious ceremony? Community witness? Consummation? Exchange of vows? Magical binding? Family blessing?

YOUR ANSWER

Describe a traditional wedding ceremony in your world:

ELEMENT	DESCRIPTION
Setting	
Who performs it	
Key rituals or moments	
Words or vows spoken	
Objects or symbols used	

What happens after the ceremony?

Reception? Consummation rituals? Wedding night traditions? Period of seclusion?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there different marriage customs for different classes, species, or magical groups?

If so, what are the key differences?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters marry, how does their ceremony differ from tradition?

Do they follow all customs, some, or none? What does this choice reveal?

YOUR ANSWER



Can people marry secretly or elope?

Is this culturally acceptable, scandalous, or meaningless without public recognition?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a secret marriage feel “real” to the people in it?

Even without official ceremony, what ritual or words would make it meaningful?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters had a secret ceremony, what would it look like?

Where would it happen? What would they say or do? Who (if anyone) would witness?

YOUR ANSWER

Death, Grief & Mourning

Death customs help shape the way a culture approaches romance and many of its most emotional moments. Rituals surrounding the dead, what is owed to the deceased, whether grief is performed publicly or hidden away, and whether remarriage is permitted or shameful. All of these factors will influence the plot of your romance. What your characters believe about the end of life will colour how they view love and ultimately how they approach it.

Death customs can provide the most obvious romantic obstacle in the form of a **mourning period**: a socially or magically enforced period of time where the bereaved are separated from the world of the living, and therefore from the world of romance. Historically, Victorian widows were expected to wear black for over two years, progressing through stages of “deep mourning” to “half mourning” in specific increments. In romantasy, mourning customs can be even more restrictive, including restrictions against dancing, socialising, wearing colours, and being visible in public. The mourning period serves to enforce a waiting period in the characters’ lives; developing romantic feelings towards another person during this time carries an added layer of guilt because wanting someone while you are supposed to be grieving the loss of someone is seen as a betrayal of the deceased.

But death customs do more than just create a waiting period; they also serve to define the characters. Are your characters careful with the dead? Do they mourn with others? Are they open with their grief, or do they keep it inside? Do your characters follow customs they don’t believe in out of a deep respect? These answers will give the reader insight into who they are at their deepest level. If a character is willing to risk their safety to retrieve a body for proper burial, this shows that they have the capacity for selfless acts of caring, and therefore they are emotionally mature. And if a character refuses to take part in the outward signs of mourning, but displays deep, genuine grief in private, this reads as more emotionally honest and complex.

Grief is the unseen force driving both central relationships in *A Court of Thorns and Roses*. Rhysand has built a whole identity on unaddressed grief for the murders of his mother and sister by Tamlin’s father and brothers. As such, he believes that anything he loves will eventually be taken away from him and keeps his true feelings and mating bond with Feyre hidden to protect himself. At the same time, Feyre is grieving the loss of her humanity, as she died and was resurrected as High Fae. The symptoms she displays (nightmares, dissociation, physical illness) are classic trauma responses, yet in the Spring Court, these are dismissed. The romantic obstacle isn’t just that Tamlin is controlling; it’s that he is unable to deal with his own grief, so he can’t hold space for hers. Because Rhysand acknowledges her pain and provides Feyre with the room to feel it, he offers something Tamlin structurally cannot. Because of this fundamental difference in how each of them experiences and processes grief, one relationship is broken, and a new one can emerge.

Death is far from abstract in *The Cruel Prince*. When Jude was only seven years old, she witnessed her parents' murder at the hands of Madoc. The Fae around her have become detached and nonchalant about death; during a royal coronation where the entire royal family is slaughtered, the celebration continues without a care. This cultural indifference to mortality is itself a source of conflict. Jude is aware that because she is mortal and the Fae are immortal, she is fragile and ephemeral, and that perception affects all of her interactions with Cardan. It is her knowledge that death is final that makes her ruthless, and it gives her an advantage over the immortals surrounding her.

In *Fourth Wing*, the dragon bond causes a series of events to occur once one partner dies: the bonded dragon dies, which kills the other bonded rider. Because there is an irrefutable mathematical certainty of shared mortality, Violet and Xaden are invested in each other's survival prior to developing an emotional connection. When Liam, Xaden's friend and Violet's protector, is killed, this is the moment that finally allows Violet to break down her defences and accept that death is not some distant concept in their world. It is this shared mourning for Liam that begins to unite them to a greater extent than before, developing a shared purpose that deepens into something more personal.

When developing mourning traditions for your world, there are several dynamics worth thinking about:

Grief as a psychological barrier. A character that has lost someone they loved will likely believe that when they lost that person, they also lost their ability to love. Therefore, a new love interest must find a way to help the character overcome the idea that loving again is a betrayal, by dismantling the character's internal beliefs that prevent them from feeling. This is a primary driver of the slow burn: the pining isn't just about external separation but about a character who won't allow themselves to feel.

Mourning as public performance. In some cultures, grief must be visible: specific clothing, wailing rituals, professional mourners, public vigils. In others, grief must be hidden; stoicism is valued, and those who visibly show their grief are viewed as weak. Both create romantic tension, but in different ways. Public mourning makes the bereaved conspicuous and untouchable. Private mourning creates a secret emotional world that only someone very close would be allowed to witness.

The taboo of loving again. In worlds with soul bonds or fated mates, the tie is frequently described as a tie that transcends death and even reincarnation. If your culture views the bond as eternal, then loving someone new isn't just moving on. It would represent a metaphysical betrayal. The "widow's veil" (literal or metaphorical) becomes an obstacle to intimacy that could not be overcome through conversation alone.

Shared mourning as a bond. When two characters grieve together, following rituals, sitting vigil, performing rites for someone they both loved, the experience creates a connection that is qualitatively different from anything else in the story. They have witnessed each other in a completely raw state, with no pretences or

social masks to hide behind. Like shared danger, shared grief can rapidly advance a relationship, because it forces individuals to present their true selves emotionally.

What are the mourning customs in your culture?

ASPECT	CUSTOM
Mourning period (how long, what's expected)	
Mourning dress or symbols	
Restrictions during mourning (social, romantic, business)	

How does your culture treat the dead?

Burial, cremation, sky burial, magical dissolution? Is there a ritual that must be performed? What happens if the rites aren't completed — does it affect the dead, the living, or both?

YOUR ANSWER

What are the rules around loving again after loss?

Is remarriage permitted? Expected? Shameful? Does it depend on how long they wait, who died, or how they died?

YOUR ANSWER

Can someone in mourning pursue romance?

Is courtship forbidden during mourning? For how long? What happens if they violate this?

YOUR ANSWER

How does grief affect your characters or their relationship?

If one character is mourning, how does this impact what's possible between them? Does shared grief bring them together?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your characters treat the dead they encounter?

A character who pauses to close a stranger's eyes or say a prayer reveals something about their capacity for tenderness. A character who walks past without looking reveals something too.

YOUR ANSWER

Life Stages & Coming of Age

Each culture establishes a point at which an individual is no longer a child, and that threshold indicates when they become eligible for romance, responsibility, and independent choice. The traditions surrounding this transition are crucial to understanding your character's past and can provide a pivotal moment within your story.

These transitions also establish natural turning points. A character who was not allowed to marry yesterday may have no problem getting married today, and that creates decisions they weren't prepared to face. The transition from childhood to adulthood could occur over a single night. In romantasy, the coming-of-age moment often coincides with the beginning of the romantic plot: the character becomes eligible, visible, or available in a way they weren't before.

What marks the transition to adulthood?

Age? Ceremony? Achievement? Magical awakening? Physical maturity?

YOUR ANSWER

What can people do as adults that they couldn't do as children?

Marry without consent? Own property? Make contracts? Use certain magic? Live independently?

YOUR ANSWER

Are your characters considered adults?

If not — how does this create obstacles? Are they defying expectations by acting before they're "ready"?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there other significant life transitions that affect your story?

Coming-of-age ceremonies, magical awakenings, trials, presentations at court, etc.?

YOUR ANSWER

Does a coming-of-age transition trigger the romantic plot?

Does your character become eligible for courtship, gain new powers, or enter a new social context because of a life transition? How does this change what's possible between them and the love interest?

YOUR ANSWER

Children & Education

A culture's beliefs are shown through how it brings up its youth. There are cultures that focus on discipline, there are cultures that focus on creativity. Some educate everyone equally; others reserve knowledge for the elite.

Think about what a childhood would be in your world. The way your characters were brought up shaped them into adults, and as adults with children or children-to-be, your answers to these questions can be very personal. Childhood backstory is one of the best methods to describe a grown person's behaviour. A child raised to fight shows affection differently than one raised to charm. Memories of upbringing deepen characterisation: what lessons stuck, what they rejected, what they wish they'd learned. And when characters discuss how they'd raise children together, they're revealing their deepest values.

How are children educated?

CLASS/GROUP	HOW THEY'RE EDUCATED
Noble/wealthy	<i>e.g., Private tutors in languages, history, etiquette; boys learn combat and governance; girls learn household management and diplomacy</i>
Middle/merchant	
Common/poor	<i>e.g., Learn their parents' trade by working alongside them; basic numeracy from market haggling; most cannot read</i>
Magical children	

How do most people learn skills and knowledge?

Apprenticeship? Formal schools? Family teaching? Religious institutions?

YOUR ANSWER

Who has access to education?

Is literacy common? Are schools available to all classes? Gender differences in education?

YOUR ANSWER

What knowledge is valued vs. dismissed?

Book learning vs. practical skills? Magical knowledge vs. mundane? Traditional knowledge vs. innovation?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there institutions that take children from their families?

Temples, military academies, magical schools, noble fostering arrangements? What does separation mean?

YOUR ANSWER

How were your main characters raised?

Their upbringing shaped who they are. What was childhood like for them?

CHARACTER	HOW THEY WERE RAISED
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Work & Professions

How does culture view work?

Is labor dignified or demeaning? Is idleness virtuous (noble leisure) or sinful? Do people identify strongly with their professions?

YOUR ANSWER

What professions are respected? Looked down upon?

STATUS	PROFESSIONS
Highly respected	
Respectable	
Necessary but low-status	
Disreputable or shameful	

How do people typically end up in their professions?

Family tradition? Personal choice? Assignment? Class restrictions?

YOUR ANSWER

PART TWO: CULTURE & ROMANCE

Festivals, Holidays & Celebrations

Special occasions have a way of shrinking time, bringing people close to one another, and heightening emotions. They're classic romance settings because the energy is different, rules may relax, and everyone is gathered in the same place.

The environment created by festivals gives characters an excuse to be different than they normally would. A character's face hidden behind a mask, the need to touch while dancing, the tradition that pairs strangers together. You can use these as excuses for intimacy your characters couldn't otherwise justify. And at the end of the festival, the urgency kicks in too. This chance won't come again.

What major festivals or celebrations exist in your world?

Describe 2-3 that matter for your story:

FESTIVAL	WHEN & WHAT IT CELEBRATES	KEY TRADITIONS

Which festival provides a romantic opportunity for your characters, and why?

WHICH FESTIVAL PROVIDES A ROMANTIC OPPORTUNITY FOR YOUR CHARACTERS, AND WHY?

What festival tradition do your characters participate in together?

Describe the scene:

YOUR ANSWER

Do festivals allow any relaxation of normal rules?

Masquerades where identity is hidden? Festivals where class mingles? Nights when normal rules are suspended?

YOUR ANSWER

Exile, Banishment & Social Death

Every society uses a most extreme form of punishment to dissuade individuals from violating the norms: total removal from society. Exile, banishment, and social death represent the ultimate consequence of choosing love over community, and the fear of being exiled provides actual weight to each transgression. This is the nuclear option. Every time your characters violate a societal norm, the possibility of exile is what makes even the smallest violations feel dangerous.

Exile in romantasy takes several forms, and the form matters for your romance:

- **Political banishment:** The state exerts its power by physically removing the character from the territory through decree, forcing them to survive in an unfamiliar or hostile environment.
- **Self-imposed exile:** A character who voluntarily becomes a pariah to protect others, hiding behind a villain's mask, leaving home to keep a secret safe. The cost is reputation and identity, and the romantic obstacle is that the love interest must see past the performance to the real person underneath.
- **Social ostracism:** The character remains physically present but is treated as invisible, contaminated, or dead. Generational guilt, racial branding, or species-based prejudice mark them as permanent outsiders within their own community.
- **Cultural divorce:** The character rejects the beliefs, religion, or traditions of their people. They're not cast out by others; they walk away. But the safety net vanishes, and the romantic relationship must replace the entire support structure they've abandoned.

What makes exile such a potent romantic stake is the fact that it forces a character to redefine who they are. A character that has been stripped of their community, their title, and their position within the social hierarchy must discover who they are without those markers. That is frightening. But it is also the prerequisite for the kind of raw vulnerability that the strongest romances require.

Jude's exile at the end of *The Wicked King* is a brilliant example of exile as romantic catalyst. After being sent back to the mortal world, the place she tried to leave her whole life, Jude is deprived of everything she had worked toward: her status, her authority, her sense of purpose. The loss of her position causes a great deal of psychological damage. She experiences nightmares where Cardan tells her she is nothing. Her post-exile reality is characterized by working menial jobs and planning her revenge from a position of complete powerlessness. What makes Jude's exile so effective as a romantic moment is that it comes directly from the love interest himself, creating a wound that is both deeply personal and entirely politically motivated. Although it is later revealed that the exile was simply a loophole (specifically worded to protect her from assassins of the court), the emotional devastation remains intact. When Jude returns, she does so not as a suppliant but as someone who has emerged from the void. The exile served as a narrative winnowing that demonstrated she is more

than her title, and therefore her restoration as High Queen carries even greater weight because she earned it back from nothing.

Social ostracism takes a physical form in *Fourth Wing*. The “marked ones,” 107 children of the Tyrrish Rebellion, bear magic tattoos that identify them as the offspring of rebels. Xaden Riorson, their leader, has 107 additional scars etched across his back, one for each child whose life he bartered his own body to save. As a result of this inherited exile, the marked ones are both condemned and distrusted by the very institution they are compelled to serve. Xaden’s romance with Violet, the daughter of the general who ordered his father’s execution, is rooted in the tension between his deep-seated distrust of the establishment and his increasing need for the woman who represents it. For Violet, choosing Xaden means sacrificing every single thing she has ever believed about her nation. They resolve this by creating something entirely new: the city of Aretia, where the marked ones will no longer bear the branding of Navarre. Xaden’s exile does not end with reintegration into the old system. It ends with the creation of a new one.

Rhysand in *ACOTAR* represents a different type of exile: the self-imposed outcast. To protect Velaris and its people, he allows the entire world to believe he is a monster. His public image is a disguise, and that disguise is the reason for his isolation. The price of the romance is that Feyre must be the only person who sees past the facade. This creates an “us versus the world” dynamic where their bond is built on shared knowledge that everyone else in their society lacks. However, Rhysand has spent centuries living in a state of psychological dislocation, performing a version of himself that is contrary to who he truly is. His grief, his gentleness, his true values are all concealed beneath the persona. Feyre’s role is not simply to love him; it is to see him, which is its own act of redemption.

The Threat vs. The Reality

The threat of exile is often more useful to your story than exile itself. When your characters can see what happens to people who crossed the same line they’re considering (a disowned sibling, a shunned former courtier, someone whose name is no longer spoken) the cost becomes concrete and personal. You don’t need to exile your protagonist to make exile matter. You just need to show them what exile looks like.

What Exile Strips Away

When building exile customs for your world, think about what the banished person loses beyond location. Do they lose their name? Their family connections? Access to magic? Their place in the afterlife? The more the exile strips away, the higher the cost of the transgression that caused it, and the more your character risks by pursuing a forbidden relationship.

The other key aspect of exile in romantasy is how it ends for the characters. Does exile result in a permanent loss of home and identity? Or can the individual escape their exile and start anew? Can an exiled character create a life outside of their homeland, and will they ever be able to overcome the shame associated with their separation from society? In some fantasy worlds exile results in a form of death sentence for the character. In other worlds exile is considered a social death, where the exiled individual lives on as a physical being but is socially invisible and unable to connect with anyone.

One of the most frequently occurring, and ultimately the most emotionally gratifying, forms of resolution for exile in romantasy is the found family. If a character has been exiled from their natural or culturally defined family, the romance provides more than a partner; it provides a new family for the exiled character. The loved ones' people become the exiled individual's people. Together they construct a home, a court, a rebellion, or a secret city which serves as a replacement for what has been taken from the individual.

The narrative resolution of found family is effective because it recognises that humans need more than romantic love to survive. A person requires community, a sense of belonging, and a sense of purpose to truly thrive. What makes the found family so emotionally powerful is that the exile established what was lost. Therefore, when readers have witnessed you remove the character from every aspect of society, witnessing that same character establish a new existence, one that is developed based upon choice rather than inheritance, carries significant emotional weight.

What does banishment or exile look like in your world?

Physical exile from the territory? Social death while remaining present? Being cut off from family, magic, or community? Loss of name, title, or identity? Inherited stigma that marks the next generation?

YOUR ANSWER

What triggers banishment?

What transgression crosses the line from punishable to unforgivable? Is there a formal process, or can it happen at one person's command?

YOUR ANSWER

Has your character seen someone else face this consequence?

Showing the cost through a secondary character makes the threat real before your protagonists face it. Who in your world has already been cast out, and what happened to them?

YOUR ANSWER

Is exile reversible in your world?

Can the banished return? What would it cost? Is there a path to redemption, or are some falls permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

What replaces the lost community?

If your character is exiled, where do they go? Who takes them in? Does the romance provide not just a partner but a new world to belong to?

YOUR ANSWER

Map your character's exile (actual or threatened):

WHAT THEY LOSE	SPECIFIC DETAILS
Home/territory	
Name/title/identity	
Family connections	
Access to magic or power	
Community/social belonging	
Sense of self	
What replaces it	

Social Hierarchy in Practice

Even if there were no laws governing how people act in society, people would still find a way to create rules of conduct based on social hierarchy. We all learn the “rules” about how to act toward those higher up in the social order and those lower down. Who enters the room first? Who speaks, and when does the listener get to speak? Who may put a hand on whom? None of this is written into a law book, yet most people understand these unspoken codes and follow them.

In cases where members of different social classes fall in love, all of these unwritten rules become critical. Will the noble acknowledge the servant’s existence? Is it acceptable for the commoner to meet the noble’s eye? All of the tension in such a relationship stems from the disconnect between the roles each partner feels obligated to follow and what they actually feel about one another.

There’s nothing quite like showing that a character has been completely invisible to the upper classes their entire life and now finds themselves truly seen by someone in a position of authority over them. That is electrifying.

You can illustrate social hierarchy through automatic behaviours: who enters the room first, who remains seated while others stand, who speaks and who waits to be spoken to. Each time your characters break one of these automatic behaviours, it indicates a shift in the balance of power. It is at the moment a noble addresses a servant with equality, or a commoner responds to their lord in kind, that the reader feels the change.

The separation of public and private behaviour can be very effective in showing hierarchy. When characters display perfect hierarchy in front of others but fall out of line once they are alone, they are essentially creating their own secret intimacy within that private space.

Look for the “slip”: when a character accidentally reaches for the other person’s hand, uses their first name, or speaks before receiving permission, and then realises what they have done. That instant of “I forgot myself” reveals the true nature of the character beneath the social mask they wear.

Additionally, allow secondary characters to reinforce the consequences of breaking those rules. A servant who observes too much, a rival who keeps track of every detail, a parent who cautions “people are starting to talk.” The hierarchy feels authentic when someone else is paying attention.

What are the unwritten rules of cross-class interaction?

ASPECT	RULE
Eye contact (allowed, forbidden, lowered)	
Forms of address	
Physical proximity	
Who speaks first	
What topics are appropriate	

What happens when someone violates these unwritten rules?

Social consequences — awkwardness, offense, whispers, retaliation:

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters are from different classes, how do they navigate interaction?

Do they follow the rules? Chafe against them? Have a private space where class doesn't apply?

YOUR ANSWER

What social space allows them to interact more freely than usual?

Markets? Festivals? Neutral territory? Magical spaces? Private chambers?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the “slip” look like between your characters?

The most revealing moments in cross-class romance are the accidental ones — a first name used without thinking, a hand reached for instinctively, eye contact held a beat too long. What moment of “I forgot myself” reveals the truth beneath the social performance?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>What the slip is</i>	<i>She calls him by his first name in front of the court — then freezes when she realises what she’s done</i>
What the slip is	
Who slips	
Who notices	
What it reveals	

How do your characters behave differently in public versus private?

When characters maintain perfect hierarchy in front of others but drop it behind closed doors, they create a secret world. What does the shift look like between your characters — and what would happen if someone saw the private version?

CONTEXT	HOW THEY INTERACT
In public (with others watching)	
In private (alone together)	
What would happen if someone saw the private version	

Language, Names & Forms of Address

The way people interact with each other is how they reveal and create intimacy. The transition from formal to informal communication can be as profound as a first kiss. In many fantasy worlds, names hold a lot of power.

To build anticipation for the name shift, establish the formality at the beginning and let it create tension. Show the characters noticing each other's names, wanting to use them differently, catching themselves. The moment of shift should have some context: who initiated it? Was it asked for, or just assumed? Did the other character reciprocate? Write the physical sensation of the name shift as well. What does a name feel like when you say it out loud for the first time? Hearing your first name said by someone who has never called you anything but your title is vulnerable. Once the shift happens, show the newness of it all: the slight stutter when speaking, the awkwardness, the feeling of being addressed in a manner different than the world addresses you. If one character begins to use the new name before the other is comfortable with it, that disparity in usage is its own form of tension.

What different forms of address exist?

TYPE	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Formal (titles, honorifics, surnames)	
Informal (first names, nicknames)	
Intimate (pet names, private names, terms of endearment)	

When is it appropriate to use informal or intimate forms?

Between family? Close friends? Lovers? Only after marriage?

YOUR ANSWER

What shift in address marks a change in relationship?

From title to first name? From formal to informal? A new nickname?

YOUR ANSWER

When do your characters shift how they address each other?

This is often a pivotal intimacy moment:

ASPECT	DETAILS
From	
To	
When and why	

Is there significance to names in your world?

True names with power? Secret names? Multiple names for different contexts?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean when one character learns the other's private or true name?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN WHEN ONE CHARACTER LEARNS THE OTHER'S PRIVATE OR TRUE NAME?

Cultural Differences Between Characters

Do your characters come from different cultural backgrounds?

If no, skip to Integration Check.

If yes:

CHARACTER	CULTURE
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

What are the key differences between their cultures?

ASPECT	CULTURE 1	CULTURE 2
Values		
Customs		
Taboos		

What does one culture do that the other finds shocking, rude, or confusing?

MISUNDERSTANDING	DESCRIPTION
1	
2	
3	

What romantic gesture from one culture means something different in the other?

This is prime territory for miscommunication and eventual understanding:

YOUR ANSWER

When do they realize they've been misunderstanding each other?

The revelation scene:

YOUR ANSWER

What cultural tradition does one character teach the other?

The intimacy of sharing worlds:

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
How does government enforce cultural norms? Which taboos are laws vs. “just” social rules? (Ref: Section 5)	
How does magic interact with cultural customs? Magical courtship rituals? Spells that detect rule-breaking? (Ref: Section 8)	
What cultural norm conflicts with your magic system? (Ref: Section 8)	
How do economic realities constrain your characters’ choices? Can they afford to defy convention? (Ref: Section 4)	
What cultural customs have religious origins? Do characters follow them out of faith or habit? (Ref: Section 6)	

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
How does your culture's attitude toward sexuality and desire affect your romance's pacing?	

Quick Reference: Cultural Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Core cultural value that most affects your romance	
Main taboo your characters break	
The reputation risk	
The touch or proximity rule that creates tension	
The courtship custom they follow or violate	
The festival or ceremony that matters	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The form of address shift (from → to → when)	
The oath or promise that conflicts with love	
The cultural attitude toward desire that your protagonist must navigate	

Final Thought

Culture Is Behaviour, Not Exposition

Don't info-dump culture. Show it through action: characters following or breaking rules, social awkwardness when norms are violated. The best cultural worldbuilding is invisible until someone breaks the rules, and then everyone knows exactly what line was crossed.